

MCD to expand waste-to-energy plants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will expand existing waste-to-energy plants and develop new such facilities to raise the city's waste-processing capacity to over 25,000 tonnes per day (TPD) by 2035, according to the Master Plan for Delhi (MPD) 2047.

The master plan, prepared by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and notified on Thursday, projects Delhi's municipal solid waste (MSW) generation to rise from 13,500 TPD in 2026 to 25,764 TPD by 2047. The master plan suggests that the increase is driven by population growth and rising per capita waste generation, which is estimated to increase from the current 0.597 kg per day to 0.783 kg per day by 2047.

Against this, the MPD 2047



projects MCD's processing capacity to rise to 25,392 TPD by 2035 and remain at that level through 2047, resulting in a shortfall of 372 TPD relative to projected generation for that year, as per the master plan.

At present, around 7,642 TPD of waste is processed, while nearly 5,858 TPD is sent to landfill sites, according to the document.

According to the MPD 2047, MCD's existing waste processing facilities include the

1,950 TPD waste-to-energy (WTE) plant at Okhla, the 2,400 TPD integrated waste processing facility at Narela-Bawana, the 1,300 TPD WtE plant at Ghazipur and the 2,000 TPD plant at Tehkhanda.

The city also has a 100 TPD compressed biogas plant at Ghoga Dairy operated by Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL), besides composters, decentralised compost pits and Material Recovery Facilities.

The MPD roadmap aims to

take processing capacity to 15,292 TPD by December 2028 through new plants and expansion of existing facilities. It proposes new 3,000 TPD and 2,000 TPD WtE plants at Narela-Bawana and Ghazipur, respectively. The Okhla plant is proposed to be expanded to 2,950 TPD by March 2027, while Tehkhanda's capacity is to rise to 3,000 TPD by December 2027.

Compressed Biogas and bio-CNG plants are also planned at Ghazipur and Okhla. The document states that the MCD has separately invited bids for an integrated fresh-waste processing facility with a minimum capacity of 5,900 TPD on land reclaimed after biomining of legacy waste at its landfill sites.

Facilities are planned at Bhalswa, Shinghola, Okhla, Bawana and Ghazipur. Work orders for the Shinghola and

Ghazipur facilities were awarded on June 16, with both expected to become operational by October 31, the plan states.

The MPD 2047 notes that Bhalswa, Ghazipur and Okhla, Delhi's three major landfill sites, have exceeded their designed capacity.

The master plan calls for reducing dependence on landfills through biomining, waste processing and recovery of recyclable material. New landfill sites will be discouraged and, if required, will be restricted to inert waste under sanitary landfilling norms. Inert waste is solid waste that is neither chemically nor biologically reactive.

Land reclaimed after biomining is proposed to be used for green and recreational purposes as well as some new waste-processing facilities, MPD 2047 states.

Master Plan bars industrial activity in Lutyens Zone, ridge, protected forests

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Master Plan for Delhi (MPD) 2047 bars all industrial activity, including household industries, in the Lutyens Bungalow Zone, the Ridge, protected forests, water body buffers and government housing colonies.

The plan sets out a fresh policy framework for industrial development across the capital, aimed at phasing out polluting units while promoting cleaner, high-value manufacturing and service industries.

Under the new rules, industrial areas that existed before 1962, or where industrial use was permitted under the 1962 Master Plan, will be allowed to continue, provided documentary evidence is furnished. However, these



areas will still be subject to restrictions on prohibited industries and pollution control norms, according to the plan.

The plan lists specific zones where no industrial activity will be permitted at all. These include the Bungalow Zones of Lutyens Delhi and Civil Lines, the Ridge, Zone O, buffers around water bodies and canals, ecologically sensitive areas, security-sensitive zones, reserved and protected forests, Cooperative

Group Housing Societies, DDA housing colonies, and government flats, bungalows and employer housing.

Industries falling under a "prohibited category," listed separately in the plan's annexures, will not be allowed anywhere in Delhi. All industrial units will be required to meet standards set by pollution control authorities, the plan states.

The plan permits conversion of industrial plots for group housing, public and semi-public facilities, commercial use and data centres, subject to existing provisions. It also allows industrial plot owners to use up to 10 per cent of their permissible floor area ratio for co-working spaces without needing formal use conversion, a measure aimed at supporting start-ups.

₹49.74 cr MSME capacity building programme launched

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched a Mega Capacity Building Programme for the city's MSME sector on Thursday. The Chief Minister announced that the Centre has approved ₹49.74 crore for Delhi under the RAMP scheme to train over 30,000 small businesses and connect more than 10,000 of them to digital markets by January 2027.

The programme, organised by the Delhi State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation (DSIIDC) at Anuvrat Bhawan, was held under the Raising



and Accelerating MSME Performance scheme. More than 200 MSME entrepreneurs attended, along with Industries Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa and senior officials.

The Chief Minister said the programme marked an important step toward what she called the "4-P Reform," covering policy, process, performance and partnership.

She said a partnership between Government and entrepreneurs could give fresh momentum to Delhi's economy.

She said the RAMP scheme funding would help link over 30,000 MSMEs to modern skills and training, while more than 10,000 businesses would be connected to digital platforms like GeM and ONDC to access larger markets. She said going digital was now essential for business competitiveness rather than optional.

The Chief Minister said improved coordination between the Centre and the Delhi government was directly benefiting traders and entrepreneurs in the city.

LG Sandhu reviews Delhi Police safety measures for women, senior citizens

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu held a review meeting with the Commissioner of Police on Thursday to assess specialised policing measures aimed at protecting women and senior citizens across the capital, according to an official statement. The meeting focused on evaluating the functioning of Delhi Police's Senior Citizen Mobile Application, the performance of Shishtachar Squads deployed against street



harassment, and the presence of security personnel on Pink Buses meant for women commuters.

Sandhu reviewed the outreach and adoption of the Senior Citizen Mobile Application, examining regis-

tration numbers and the frequency of interaction between local police and elderly residents, according to the statement. He directed police to ensure faster grievance redressal, stronger emergency response mecha-

nisms and regular visits by local officers to elderly residents across the city.

The LG also instructed police to reassess the total number of registered senior citizens under the scheme and expand the application's reach accordingly, the statement said.

On women's safety, Sandhu reviewed the deployment and ground-level performance of Shishtachar Squads, which are tasked with curbing street harassment and maintaining public order near schools, transit hubs and crowded markets.

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e - TENDER

Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the following work :

Tender No. D26750015: Reconstruction of Low Height Boundary Wall Adjacent to Ring Road and face lifting of Control Room Building at 220kV S/S'n Naraina.

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites:-
<https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_296956_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0147-180826
Last date for bid submission: **17.09.2026, 13:00 Hrs.**

All Corrigendum/ Addendum/ Amendments/ Date of Extension/Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

IN THE COURT OF DR. PANKAJ SHARMA, DJ-42, NEW DELHI DISTRICT, PATIALA HOUSE COURT, NEW DELHI

Case No. PC/16/2026 / ND0H 15.10.2026

RAMAKRISHNA MISSION VS STATE OF NCT OF DELHI

1. Ramakrishna Mission, Through Shwari Saravakolanda, Secretary, Delhi Mission, Ramakrishna Ashram Marg, New Delhi-110055

Petitioners

Vs

2. State of NCT of Delhi, Through its Chief Secretary, Delhi Secretariat, I, P. Estate, New Delhi-110002..... Respondents

Whereas a petition under section 276 of the Indian Succession Act, 1925 for the grant of Probate/Letters of Administration to the petitioner in respect of the movable and immovable property of the estate of Late. Dr. Sunila Malik.

Notice is hereby given to the general public that any person having objection to the Grant of Letter of Administration/Probate in his favour in respect of the estate of the deceased party/ House No. F-4/13, Poonji Marg, Vasant Vihar, New Delhi-110055, as per annexure P2, attached herewith in respect of Moveable Assets" may file the same in the court personally or through counsel on or before the next date of hearing 15.10.2026.

Given under my hand and the seal of the court on the 24th day of July 2026

DJ-42 & Waqf Tribunal (ND0H), Patiala House Courts, New Delhi

ANNEXURE P2

DETAILS OF SAVINGS ACCOUNTS, FIXED DEPOSITS AND OTHER INVESTMENTS OF TESTATOR NAMELY LATE DR. (MRS.) SHUNILA MALIK IN KNOWLEDGE OF PETITIONER AS ON DATE OF FILING OF THE PRESENT PETITION.

I. SAVINGS ACCOUNTS				
S.No.	Bank Name & Branch	Account No.	Balance	
1.	State Bank of India, C-19 Shopping Complex, Paschim Marg, Vasant Vihar, New Delhi 110057.	0415457349	Rs.13,67,787	
2.	HDFC	00111570006474 00111000144496		
3.	Punjab National Bank, H22, Connaught Place, Tropical Building New Delhi 110001	013300010028128		
4.	Canara Bank, C-18, Shopping Centre No.1, Paschim Marg, Vasant Vihar, New Delhi 110057	90312030004612		

1. Bank Name: STATE BANK OF INDIA					
Branch: Vasant Vihar, C-19 Shopping Complex, Paschim Marg, New Delhi 110057					
S.No.	Account No.	Value as on April 2025 (in Rs.)	S.No.	Account No.	Value as on April 2025 (in Rs.)
i.	30074816779	9,96,261	viii.	38683164119	3,98,806
ii.	30910226891	2,61,100	ix.	39051009186	0,01,540
iii.	3171727557	34,43,986	x.	39874934379	18,84,328
iv.	3252566518	4,00,000	xi.	40220126702	23,62,404
v.	33227819515	8,14,731	xii.	40493480712	11,82,271
vi.	33369124161	8,07,865	xiii.	41914750371	5,38,599
vii.	35323126471	5,10,751	xiv.	42368462447	5,38,553
Total					1,49,41,515

2. Bank Name: CANARA BANK (Branch: Vasant Vihar, New Delhi)	
---	--

2. Bank Name: CANARA BANK Branch: Vasant Vihar, New Delhi						
Account No.	Deposit Amount	Value date	Term (Months-Days)	Interest Rate (% p.a.)	Maturity Date	Maturity Amount (in Rupees)
14000107335	11,05,358	07/10/2023	24 M	7.35	07/10/2025	12,78,688
14013716449	5,79,488	17/04/2025	400 D	7.35	22/05/2026	6,27,184
14016740780	5,64,971	09/08/2024	666 D	7.35	06/06/2026	6,45,295
14018243865	10,00,000	20/09/2024	444 D	7.85	20/12/2025	10,39,255
14019343736	8,59,998	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	9,44,215
14018343843	5,38,864	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	5,92,321
14018343914	4,15,911	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	4,57,172
14018343974	7,60,364	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	8,35,796
14018343460	11,70,064	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	12,86,140
14018344113	21,72,230	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	23,36,779
14018344789	4,20,437	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	20/12/2025	4,73,140
14019345220	74,33,910	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	81,17,709
14018345862	12,56,249	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	13,60,876
14018346340	7,89,306	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	8,67,609
14018344708	7,95,347	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	8,74,250
14018344763	6,73,581	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	7,40,405
14018344231	4,25,448	27/09/2024	444 D	7.85	15/12/2025	5,02,500
14018467480	2,98,048	02/10/2024	444 D	7.85	20/12/2025	3,27,615
14019486393	12,01,586	30/10/2024	444 D	7.85	21/12/2025	13,25,185
14020398922	5,00,000	30/12/2024	444 D	7.85	19/03/2026	5,49,603
		Total			1,43,60,420	15,63,687

3. Bank Name: HDFC Bank Branch: Vasant Vihar, New Delhi						
Account No.	Deposit Amount	Deposit Start Date	Period (Months-Days)	Interest Rate	Maturity Date	Maturity Amount
5030090062566	1,00,000	07/05/2023	12 M + 1 D	7.1	08/05/2024	1,07,327

IV. LIC				
Policy No.	Amount Claimable	Folio No.	Share Amount Claimable	
113915659	Rs. 2,66,665 approx.	17880525	Rs. 31,000 approx.	

V. MUTUAL FUNDS 1. FRANKLIN TEMPLETON				
Folio No.	Share Amount Claimable	Folio No.	Unit Balance on Record Date	Dividend Amt.
723473	Rs. 17,863 approx.	1008448857	Rs. 46,317.416	Rs. 2843.89
1950272	Rs. 28,983 approx.			30.06.2005
1950219	Rs. 8,84,571 approx.			
411398	Rs. 17,95,744 approx.			
	Rs. 27,27,161 approx.			

4. UTI				
Folio No.	Share Amount Claimable	Folio No.	Share Amount Claimable	
517251598307	Rs. 7,77,000 approx.			

5. HDFC				
CAS Consolidated Account Statement 01 Feb 2018 to 28 Feb 2018				
NSDL Demat /Ac	HDFC Bank DP ID: IN301151	No. Of ISINs/Schemes	2	Value
	Client ID: 21892666			Rs. 4,08,763.60
Mutual Fund Folios	9 Folios	No. Of ISINs/Schemes	14	Rs. 1,08,43,717.23
In the Joint Names of Mutual Fund Folios	3 Folios	C M Malik [AAPM3678N]	4	24,17,450.26
		No. Of ISINs/Schemes	4	
		Grand Total		Rs. 1,36,69,931.09

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of BINEETA SAHU who is purchasing BUILT-UP PROPERTY No. M-212, AREA MEASURING 68.5 sq. yds. i.e. 57.28 sq. mt. being part of Property No. 13127 built on old Plot No. 20 out of Khalsa No. 806 situated at the Revenue Estate of Village Mirzapur, Colony Known as Vijay Enclave, New Delhi-110045 from Mrs. Shashi Gang who owned the subject property vide Notarized General Power of Attorney, Agreement to sell and Will dated 12.07.2012, now BINEETA SAHU intend to mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LIMITED, So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP, N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of SIMPLE AHUJA who is purchasing Property No. C-3, Second Floor Back Side Without Roof Rights, Plot No. 18, Khalsa No. 26011 Min (0-2-10), 260/2 Min (0-2-10) and 257 Min South (0-5-0) Village-Sattari, Chhatpur, Tehsil-Satli (M.G Road) Near Delhi-110074 from Mrs. Complete Home Solution (a partnership firm) who had owned the subject property on the basis of Notarized General Power of Attorney, Agreement to sell and Will dated 21.11.2022, from Mr. Mahesh Agarwal, now SIMPLE AHUJA intend to purchase and mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LIMITED, So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP, N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

SECUR INDUSTRIES LIMITED

Regd Off: 707, Seventh Floor, Devika Tower, Chandler Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, India, 201011, CIN: U74120UP1989PLC019383

Email: agar.bol.net.in@gmail.com, Website: www.securindustriesltd.in, Contact: 0120-4107504

NOTICE OF 37TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, E-VOTING INFORMATION AND BOOK CLOSURE

- Notice is hereby given that the 37th Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the members of M/s. Secur Industries Limited (CIN: U74120UP1989PLC019383) ("the Company") will be held on **Saturday, 19th day of September, 2026 at 12:00 P.M.** IST through Video-Conferencing/Other Audio-visual means (VC/OAVM) to transact the businesses as set out in the Notice of AGM in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 (Act) and Rules framed thereunder read with General Circular issued from time to time, respectively circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circulars").
- Electronic copies of the Notice of the AGM and the Annual Report for the financial year ended March 31, 2026 of the Company has been sent to all the members, whose email ids are registered with the Company/RTA/Depository participant(s), as on the cut-off date i.e., **14th August, 2026**. Please note that the requirement of sending physical copy of the Notice of the AGM and Annual Report to the Members will also be available and can be downloaded from the website of the Company www.securindustriesltd.in.
- The facility of casting the votes by the members ("e-voting") will be provided by **Central Depository Services (India) Limited (CDSL)** and the detailed procedure for the same is provided in the Notice of the AGM. The remote e-voting period commences on **16th September, 2026 (09:00 A.M.)** and end on **18th September, 2026 (05:00 P.M.)**. During this period, members of the Company, holding shares either in physical form or in dematerialized form, as on the cut-off date of **12th September, 2026**, may cast their vote by remote e-voting or by e-voting at the time of AGM. Members participating through VC/OAVM shall be counted for reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Act.
- Members, who are holding shares in physical/electronic form and their e-mail addresses are not registered with the Company/their respective Depository Participants, are requested to register their e-mail addresses at the earliest by sending scanned copy of a duly signed letter by the Member(s) mentioning their name, complete address, folio number, number of shares held with the Company along with self-attested scanned copy of the PAN Card and self-attested scanned copy of any one of the following documents viz., Aadhar Card, Driving License, Election Card, Passport, utility bill or any other Govt. document in support of the address proof of the Member as registered with the Company for receiving the Annual Report 2025-26 along with AGM Notice by email to agar.bol.net.in@gmail.com. Members holding shares in demat form can update their email address with their Depository Participants. The notice of the AGM contains the instructions regarding the manner in which the shareholders can cast their vote through remote e-voting or by e-voting at the time of AGM.
- The Register of Members and Share Transfer books of the Company will remain closed from **Sunday, 13th September, 2026 to Saturday, 19th September, 2026** (both days inclusive).
- The Notice of AGM and Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 sent to members in accordance with the applicable provisions in due course.

Secur Industries Limited

Sd/-

Ashutosh Agrawal

Managing Director

DIN: 00421089

Place: Ghaziabad

Date: 20.08.2026

UNITY

Small Finance Bank

5th Floor, Tower 1, Seawoods Grand Central, Sec-40, Seawoods, above Seawoods Darave Railway Station, Navi Mumbai – 400 706

DEMAND NOTICE

UNDER THE PROVISIONS OF THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 ("the Act") AND THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002 ("the Rules")

The undersigned being the authorized officer of **Unity Small Finance Bank Limited** under the Act and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) of the Act read with the Rule 3, issued Demand Notice(s) under Section 13(2) of the Act, calling upon the following borrower(s) to repay the amount mentioned in the respective notice(s) within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The undersigned reasonably believes that borrower(s) is/are avoiding the service of the demand notice(s), therefore the service of notice is being effected by affixation and publication as per Rules. The contents of demand notice(s) are extracted herein below:

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)	Demand Notice Date & Amount	Description of secured assets (Immovable Property)
1.	Loan A/C. No(S): USFBDELLOAN000005016512 & USFBDELLOAN000005010678 S/o. Prem Chand Deswal 2. Sneh Deswal Alias Sneh Lata Parswal D/o. Prem Lal Parswal	23.07.2026 Rs. 9,18,436.41/- (Rupees Nine Lakhs Eighteen Thousand Four Hundred Thirty-Six And Forty-One Paise Only) Rs. 10,19,194.32/- (Rupees Ten Lakh Nineteen Thousand One Hundred Ninety Four And Thirty-Two Only) As On 15.07.2026 NPA Date: 05.05.2026	All That Piece And Parcel Of The Property Admeasuring Plot Area 3 Marla Area Measuring 105 Sq.yds, Out Of Khewat No 187 Khata No 213, Mu No 66, Killa No 12/2 (7-13), Situated At Maulja-Hatin, Tehsil-Hatin, Distt- Palwal And Bounded As Follows:- Surrounded By Boundaries :- (As Per Technical)

Delhi to get 30-40 lakh new homes under Master Plan 2047: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday said the “Delhi Master Plan 2047” is not merely a document but a comprehensive roadmap for the overall development of Delhi. The master plan proposes a target to build 30 to 40 lakh new homes in the capital and expand the Metro network to nearly 700 kilometres. The Chief Minister called the plan a long-term roadmap for the city’s development.

Speaking after unveiling the master plan, the Chief Minister said the plan had been prepared keeping Delhi’s projected population of around 3.20 crore by 2047 in mind, with a particular

focus on affordable housing. She said residents of older colonies who had long awaited redevelopment would now benefit from a higher floor area ratio, or FAR, and improved facilities under the new provisions.

The Chief Minister credited coordination between the central and Delhi governments for the plan, thanking Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal, and Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu for their roles in its preparation.

On slum rehabilitation, the Chief Minister said the plan would advance the “Jahan Jhuggi, Wahan Makan” policy, under which eligible fami-



lies living in slum clusters would be provided housing at the same location. She said the Delhi Development Authority and the Delhi government would work togeth-

er on this, including development through a public-private partnership model.

The chief minister said Delhi’s Metro network, currently spanning around 416

kilometres, is planned to be extended to 695 kilometres under the new plan. She added that the plan also includes 52 kilometres of cycle tracks along both banks of the

Yamuna River and a connected network of parks, alongside integrated development of buses, the Regional Rapid Transit System, multimodal transport hubs and pedestrian infrastructure.

The Chief Minister said the plan permits ground-floor commercial activity on all roads that are 30 metres wide or more, a move she said would benefit local traders and boost employment in neighbourhood markets.

On regulatory changes, the Chief Minister said the number of land-use and premises categories under Delhi’s development rules has been reduced from 133 to 45 to simplify the approval process. She said the plan also proposes linking land-use data to a GIS plat-

form, introducing Transferable Development Rights, and setting up a single-window online system for processes including transit-oriented development, change of land use, and layout plan approvals.

The chief minister said the plan makes provisions for new economic sectors such as data centres, integrated industrial parks, co-working spaces, startup hubs and cloud kitchens, describing this as an effort to prepare Delhi’s economy for future employment needs.

The Chief Minister also said the plan eases rules for setting up schools, colleges, nursing and paramedical institutions, and healthcare facilities, with the aim of expanding educa-

tion and health infrastructure in the city.

She said the plan covers rural areas, unauthorised colonies, slum clusters, markets, low-density zones, educational and health infrastructure, warehousing, farmhouses, forest areas, parks, the Yamuna floodplain and cultural facilities.

The Chief Minister said the Delhi government intends to implement the plan on the ground rather than leave it as a policy document, linking it to the central government’s “Viksit Bharat 2047” vision.

The statement did not specify a timeline for the phased rollout of individual components of the plan, including the housing and Metro expansion targets.

MPD proposes 100-floor buildings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi’s skyline may look different in coming decades as a master plan proposes structures having more than 100 floors in the city. According to the Master Plan of Delhi 2047 (MPD 2047), notified on Thursday by the Centre, tall buildings will be encouraged in areas with proper infrastructure, particularly those along mass transit corridors and in major commercial and mixed-use centres.



Minister of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) Manohar Lal Khattar said the master plan removes height restrictions from residential and commercial buildings from most of the city areas.

According to the master plan, no height has been suggested for different categories of buildings in plotted housing, in-situ rehabilitation, mixed land use, godowns, and group housing areas.

The building plans will have to be cleared by statutory bodies, depending on the Floor Area Ratio (FAR) of that particular category of land permitted by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

Starting with in-situ slum rehabilitation buildings, DDA has allowed a minimum of 2,000 sqm, with FAR of 500 FAR and no specific height

restrictions.

“Clubbing of scattered slums with JJ sites in the neighbourhood, within 3 km, may be done to work out an overall comprehensive scheme. In the case of comprehensive schemes, the slums, JJ clusters, may be rehabilitated on any of the clubbed plots, and the remaining plots can be utilised for remunerative purposes,” the MPD says.

The master plan also allows commercial activities in residential areas on the ground floor of roads having a width of 30 metres or more.

The existing norms allow commercial activities only on mixed-use streets and commercial streets already notified by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD).

“Commercial activities in residential plots abutting streets and roads having a width of 30 metres right of way (ROW) and more, in all categories of colonies, which are neither notified as mixed use nor as commercial streets, shall be permitted on the ground floor or first lower floor, in the case of stilt (parking), subject to payment of charges,” the MPD reads.

All types of commercial activities are permitted on such residential plots except activities involving any kind of obnoxious, hazardous, inflammable, non-compatible and polluting substances or processes, only on the ground floor or first lower floor (in case of stilt), it says.

MPD eyes air taxis, waterways, EV bus fleet expansion

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Master Plan for Delhi (MPD) 2047 outlines a sweeping transport overhaul, proposing new modes of mobility, including air taxis, air pods and inland waterway transport along the Yamuna, alongside a major push to expand the city’s electric bus fleet and rationalise its road network. According to the plan document, the strategy aims to improve internal mobility, reduce congestion, and shift more trips toward public transport and intermediate public transport, moving away from private vehicles.

The plan calls for clean fuel adoption, advanced transit

systems, and artificial intelligence-based traffic and parking management, alongside exploring inland waterways through the Yamuna, the Sahibi River, and canals, as well as air-based transport options.

On regional connectivity, the plan notes that air travel is currently served primarily by Indira Gandhi International Airport, with seamless multimodal connectivity planned to the upcoming Noida International Airport at Jewar through road, rail or other future modes. The document also references proposed high-speed rail corridors linking Delhi to Varanasi, Ahmedabad and Amritsar or Chandigarh, aimed at cutting



travel time and pollution.

The plan highlights the Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) as a key decongestion tool, listing eight proposed corridors connecting Delhi to towns across the National Capital Region, including Ghaziabad-Meerut, Gurugram,

Panipat-Karnal, Faridabad-Palwal, Bahadurgarh-Rohtak and Shahadra-Baraut, with the Delhi-Ghaziabad-Meerut corridor already operational across 80 km.

Four strategic transport links have also been proposed to improve high-speed

connectivity to regional economic hubs such as Gurugram, Greater Noida, Jewar Airport and the AIIMS campus in Jhajjar, including extensions of Urban Extension Road I and II and a direct link from Dwarka to Gurugram’s HUDA City Centre.

On the road network, the plan notes Delhi has roughly 33,000 km of roads structured in a ring-radial pattern. It sets out a road hierarchy ranging from National Highways with a recommended 90-metre right of way down to arterial, sub-arterial, collector roads and local streets, with segregated pedestrian and cycling infrastructure mandated wherever feasible.

Delhi needs 401 MGD more water by 2047, master plan projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi will require an additional 401 million gallons of water per day, or MGD, by 2047 to meet the city’s growing needs, according to projections by the Delhi Jal Board included in the Master Plan for Delhi 2047.

To bridge this gap, the DJB has proposed augmenting supply by 110 MGD over the next four to five years through short- to medium-term measures, followed by a further 291 MGD over the next 10 to 15 years through medium to long-term interventions, the plan states.

These measures include substituting Yamuna River water currently used for irrigation with treated wastewater, procuring additional raw water from Uttar Pradesh, and



developing upstream storage projects at Renukaji, Lakhwar and Kishau, according to the plan.

The Master Plan notes that achieving these augmentation targets will require coordinated efforts with neighbouring states, particularly Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Himachal Pradesh, along with facil-

itation and intervention from the central government.

According to DJB figures cited in the plan, Delhi’s water supply stood at 935 MGD in 2021, against an estimated demand of 1,380 MGD in the same year. By 2047, the board estimates that potable water demand in the city will rise to around 1,600 MGD.

On sanitation, the plan states that the DJB is responsible for the city’s wastewater network, covering collection, treatment, and reuse or disposal of sewage. Delhi currently manages wastewater through a combination of a sewage distribution network and on-site systems such as septic tanks, according to the plan.

The DJB has also planned decentralised wastewater treatment

systems and sludge management measures aimed at preventing the discharge of untreated sewage into drains, the plan states.

In areas where laying sewer lines is not feasible, the DJB plans to capture untreated effluent from sub-drains through a parallel system called the Interceptor Sewer Project, which aims to trap and treat sewage before it reaches the Yamuna River, according to the plan.

The DJB is also working to intercept sewage flowing directly into the Yamuna through major drains by diverting the flow to the nearest sewage treatment plants, the plan states. Of the 22 major drains identified in Delhi, 11 have already been intercepted to prevent untreated effluent from entering the river, according to the plan.

MPD-2047 proposes treatment of 22 drains to rejuvenate Yamuna



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The proposed Master Plan for Delhi-2047 envisages intercepting and treating all 22 drains discharging into the Yamuna through sewage treatment, constructed wetlands and bio-remediation as part of a series of measures aimed at rejuvenating the river and its floodplains.

The plan proposes that the active floodplain should be a ‘no construction zone’ and only recreational uses should be permitted. All unauthorised construction, including religious structures, should be demolished by the concerned agency on priority.

The master plan, which was unveiled on Thursday, also proposes restoring the intercepted drain corridors and seamlessly integrating them with green spaces and floodplains to create continuous ecological corridors.

It strictly prohibits the discharge of untreated or unregulated sewage, wastewater, industrial effluents and solid waste into the Yamuna and other water bodies.

The measures are part of the “Special initiatives for the rejuvenation of River

Yamuna and its floodplains” outlined in the Master Plan for Delhi (MPD) 2047.

The plan notes that Delhi is a river city whose history and cultural ethos are closely linked with the Yamuna and its floodplains.

The master plan proposes ecological restoration of the Yamuna along the 22-kilometre stretch between Wazirabad Barrage and Okhla Barrage and implementation of 13 major restoration projects covering around 1,700 hectares of the Yamuna floodplains.

These projects will focus on restoring wetlands, natural depressions, floodplain ecosystems and biodiversity, while also enhancing climate resilience and groundwater recharge, according to the plan. The plan proposes desilting existing wetlands and restoring them to facilitate floodwater catchment, besides creating new wetlands by developing and deepening existing depressions into storage basins.

These wetlands would complement floodplain forests and grasslands planted with riverine species, providing habitats for biodiversity, the plan said.

Delhi Master Plan proposes licence suspension for serious illegal parking

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Master Plan for Delhi (MPD) 2047 proposes suspension of driving licences and cancellation of vehicle registrations in serious cases of unauthorised parking.

It also proposes congestion charges in busy areas to curb traffic and reduce dependence on private vehicles. The plan, prepared by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and unveiled by Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal on Thursday, seeks to shift Delhi’s approach from simply creating more parking spaces to managing demand through dynamic pricing and stricter regulations.

Under the MPD-2047, busy markets and commercial hubs will be identified as Parking Management Areas, where local bodies can reg-



ulate parking, mark no-parking zones and levy charges based on demand and congestion.

It proposes higher parking fees in congested areas and discourages on-street parking near public transport hubs and multi-level parking facilities.

The plan calls for linking new vehicle registrations to parking availability and gradually regulating on-street parking in residential colonies through permits. It proposes heavy penal-

ties for unauthorised parking on roads and footpaths, with suspension of driving licences or cancellation of vehicle registrations in serious cases.

Separately, congestion pricing zones may be identified around transit-oriented development (TOD) nodes, the Walled City Heritage Zone and the Metropolitan City Centre.

The plan also envisages parking apps, providing real-time information on availability and charges.

Right to walk: Delhi Master Plan-2047 proposes pedestrian-only streets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi’s Master Plan-2047 proposes a citywide “right to walk” network, pedestrian-only streets and multi-utility zones that could bring everything from drinking water and childcare facilities to street vendors, cycle-sharing and parking onto redesigned roads.

The plan proposes multi-utility zones along streets to accommodate seating, garbage bins, signage, public conveniences, restrooms, childcare rooms, drinking

water facilities, street vendors and kiosks, utility lines, parking and public cycle-sharing systems, while ensuring that clear walking space remains available for pedestrians.

It also proposes a citywide network of safe, shaded, universally accessible and continuous pathways integrated with public transport under the “right to walk” approach. Areas with high pedestrian footfall, including busy commercial areas, heritage precincts and areas identified for a 24-hour economy, will be design-



nated as Active Travel Areas.

High-footfall areas may also be designated as pedes-

trian-only or non-motorised transport (NMT)-only zones, with tactical urbanism mea-

sures used to turn streets into fully pedestrian areas.

New developments under land-pooling, Transit Oriented Development (TOD) and regeneration schemes will also be treated as Active Travel Areas.

The plan calls for continuous active-travel networks connecting cultural hubs and other active-travel corridors along roads with a right of way (ROW) of more than 30 metres, where feasible, as well as along cycling high-ways and greenways along natural drains and the Yamuna.

For safer movement, new and existing roads will have barrier-free footpaths and cycle tracks, while at-grade crossings, pedestrian phases at busy signals and Pelican crossings near schools and markets will be encouraged.

A pelican crossing is a type of pedestrian crossing with traffic signals for both pedestrians and vehicular traffic, activated by call buttons for pedestrians. Subways and foot overbridges, where required, may include commercial activities and public art, while traffic-calming measures will also be introduced.

IN FOCUS



A lime butterfly collects nectar from red jungle geranium flowers at Nanoor in Birbhum district, West Bengal on Thursday

PTI

Yogi pushes industry-ITI link for skilled youth jobs in UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday directed officials to strengthen links between industrial units and Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs), align courses with industry requirements and promote apprenticeships and on-the-job training to expand employment opportunities for skilled youth.

Reviewing the action plan of the Department of Vocational Education, Skill Development and Entrepreneurship, Adityanath said regular employment fairs should be organised at every divisional headquarters, and skill development should be linked not only to domestic



jobs but also to global employment opportunities. "Skill development should also be linked with global opportunities along with employment," he said, stressing the need for continuous dialogue between ITIs and industries.

According to a press statement, the chief minis-

ter also directed officials to operationalise the Centre for Innovation, Invention, Incubation and Training (CIIT) in Gorakhpur, Muzaffarnagar and Bareilly at the earliest. He said they should be developed as centres of excellence for modern technology and industry-based training.

The meeting was informed that 150 Government ITIs are being upgraded with the support of Tata Technologies, while the process of upgrading another 62 ITIs is underway. Advanced skill laboratories have also been established in 37 Government ITIs with industry support.

Emphasising the role of instructors in ensuring quality training, Adityanath directed officials to expedite their selection and make provisions to give selected instructors weightage in regular appointments based on their experience and work. Officials said the selection process for 2,406 instructor posts had been completed and more than 2,200 selected instructors had already joined duty.

Five injured in firecracker unit blast in West Bengal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

At least five people, including a woman, were injured in a blast at a firecracker unit in West Bengal's South 24 Parganas district on Thursday, police said.

The explosion took place at the factory in Champahati area around noon, following which a fire broke out at the unit, a senior officer said.

Two of the injured were stated to be in critical condition, while three others were treated at a nearby hospital and later discharged, officials said. A probe has been launched to ascertain the exact cause of the blast and verify whether the unit had the requisite licence and was following safety norms, the officer said.

According to locals, firecracker-making activities were being carried out in a makeshift structure on a plot some distance from a residential area when the explosion took place.

The exact cause of the blast is yet to be ascertained.

Tension gripped the area after residents protested, alleging that fire brigade personnel reached the spot late.

A large police contingent was deployed to control the situation. Additional SP of Baruipur Police District Atish Biswas was also present at the site.

The blast left the structure largely destroyed, with its tin roof and other parts collapsing. Burnt bamboo and other material lay scattered around the site. Trees in the surrounding area were also damaged.

"We are investigating the circumstances leading to the explosion and are also verifying whether firecrackers were being manufactured there illegally. A detailed investigation has been initiated," the policeman said.

Police from Baruipur police station are examining whether the unit had the necessary permissions and whether safety regulations were being followed.

Incidentally, Wednesday's incident comes months after a blast at a firecracker unit in Champahati in January claimed one life.

Several Illegal firecracker-making units across South 24 Parganas, North 24 Parganas, Paschim Medinipur and Nadia districts have witnessed blasts in the past.

Notices issued to 1,268 drivers in Maharashtra over lack of working knowledge of Marathi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Notices were issued to 1,268 commercial passenger vehicle drivers — mainly auto rickshaw and taxi drivers — for not having adequate knowledge of Marathi on the first day of State-wide checking on Thursday, Maharashtra Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik said.

The notices were issued by the Regional Transport Offices (RTOs) across the state, and these drivers were given one month to acquire the required working knowledge of the state's primary language, failing which their badges will be suspended for three months, the minister said.

A total of 8,217 drivers were tested till Thursday evening, including 3,995 in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), Sarnaik stated in a release.

In the MMR, 604 drivers were found to be lacking working knowledge of Marathi. In the rest of the state, 4,222 drivers were tested and 664 were issued notices, the minister said.



The checking drive will continue until September 30, he said.

"Possessing working knowledge of Marathi is not merely a matter of following rules but is also about the convenience and safety of pas-

sengers," the minister said. After announcing in May that basic proficiency in Marathi is compulsory, the state Government introduced a course in Marathi for the benefit of non-Marathi drivers. It had also

set a deadline of August 15 for them to learn Marathi. Drivers were put through a 16-question test during Thursday's checking drive.

"Mala CNG bharayche aahe. Thode thambave lage!" (I need to fill

up with CNG, we'll have to stop for a while); "majhi rickshaw/taxi sharing-chi aahe" (my auto/taxi is a shared one); and "meter chalu kele aahe" (have started the meter) were among the responses that officials expected from the drivers. A senior RTO official said the questionnaire was based on the Marathi language training imparted to taxi and autorickshaw drivers by the Konkan Sahitya Parishad, which ended on Independence Day. According to RTO officials, the questions deal with situations that drivers encounter in their daily work. They include asking passengers where they want to go, understanding directions, and communicating about fares, meters, routes and taxi or autorickshaw stands.

"If after one month they are still unable to answer the questions satisfactorily, their badge will be suspended for three months. They will again be given a month to learn the language. This action will continue," said an RTO inspector conducting the checking at Dadar in central Mumbai.

FROM PAGE - 1

much pressure and a few people were doing politics over this; they were not trying to understand things. It is true that those who are already in service might have felt injustice being done. Let's see what happens now..."

Almora retreat cancels naked yoga course

"The police contacted the hotel owner during the inquiry. He said that he was also unaware of the details of the proposed event and how it was being organised," Ghodke said. Following discussions with the owner, the programme was cancelled, he added.

The retreat owner Piyush Kumar confirmed the cancellation. "The naked yoga programme has been cancelled," he said. Kumar said that the organiser had also been informed that no activity violating the decency and traditions of Uttarakhand would be allowed at the property.

The development comes days after details of the proposed programme surfaced online. According to the organiser's website, the course was scheduled from October 1 to 30 and included daily yoga practice and study, a tantra yoga manual, certification, food, accommodation, ceremonies and excursions.

The organiser, Carla Zurcher, who uses the name Yogini Kamadevi, is from England and had earlier confirmed that she was organising the programme. The programme was advertised for fees ranging from \$3,300 to \$5,700 with a 20 per cent deposit required. Almora district magistrate Anshul Singh had earlier said that neither the retreat nor the organisation had approached the administration for permission. He had directed police to verify the event and the cyber cell to investigate related social media posts.

Ram temple faces fresh scrutiny

On his recommendation, the main construction contract went to Larsen & Toubro (L&T). Misra also chose Design Associate, a Noida-based firm led by Jai Kaktikar, for design and related work. Rai claims that Misra selected the committee members himself and that some of them visited Ayodhya only once or twice in six years. In contrast, former NBCC Chairman Anoop Mittal attended meetings regularly with Misra.

Rai said that even though construction decisions were made in meetings, changes were often made afterwards, and Misra's preferences usually took priority. He also claimed that Misra's choices were favoured when selecting people and companies for the project. Rai said suggestions from other committee members were often ignored or not taken seriously.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the Ram Temple's foundation stone in August 2020. Since then, the trust and the construction committee led by Misra have overseen the project. L&T has handled the main construction, while other chosen firms have managed design and architecture.

Rai's resignation itself followed the reported theft of offerings from the temple

complex, an incident that drew public attention and prompted administrative action within the trust. His decision to quit the general secretary's post on June 26, and the formal acceptance of that resignation on July 6, set the stage for the subsequent release of the detailed letter.

Trust officials have not yet responded to the specific claims in the nine-page letter. Nripendra Misra, who previously held important administrative roles, including Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, has kept a low profile regarding the construction committee's daily work. The trust is still overseeing the remaining work at the site, while large numbers of devotees have been visiting the temple since its consecration in January 2024.

Allegations, if pursued further, could prompt closer scrutiny of the decision-making processes that guided the multi-crore project. For now, Rai's letter records his perspective on how the construction committee was formed, how contracts were awarded, and how much input different members had during the six years of building.

Observers point out that the trust's 15 members include religious leaders, administrators, and technical experts. Many will be watching to see how the trust responds, given the national importance of the Ayodhya temple project. Spiritual and architectural achievements raise questions of governance and transparency within the trust that managed Ram Mandir construction.

A workplace shooting in Lucknow opens a trail...

The claims in the message have not been independently confirmed. Soon after the shooting at the bank, Pragya Mishra posted on social media to express concern after hearing about the incident. Police recovered weapons from the second crime scene. They are still investigating the exact movements between the two locations, the couple's marital history, and any other possible factors.

Air taxis, 100-storey towers in Delhi's ambitious 2047 plan

Lal called it a historic day for Delhi and said the plan is aligned with the Viksit Bharat vision, aims to transform Delhi into a world-class, inclusive and economically vibrant city.

He said that fast development of the city, with the preservation of 180sqkm of the Yamuna floodplains and the Ridge area, will be ensured in the coming years.

Delhi currently has a population of around 2.40 crore. The city also has 520 sq km of agricultural land and 180 sq kms of ridge and forest area, which Lal said must be protected.

Transit Oriented Development Policy will facilitate affordable housing, Lal said, adding no

SC panel to probe police conduct in NEET protests

Specific accusations include the use of pellet guns, electric batons, lathi charges and tear gas without enough warning and disproportionate use of violence by Delhi Police and other agencies. Some of these actions reportedly caused serious and lasting injuries. The panel will review the chain of command behind these actions, identify those responsible, and determine whether any laws, rules or norms were violated.

A major area of concern is the issue of targeted acts of violence, harassment and molestation of female protesters. Because these are serious and sensitive issues, the Supreme Court has told the committee to treat them as a top priority.

The committee will also check if police actions were appropriate and reasonable. Other topics include police surveillance, medical care and compensation for victims, and whether certain types of projectiles or pellets should be banned.

The court also noted claims that police officers were victims of violence. It has ordered that video footage and CCTV recordings from July 20 be given to the committee for review.

Shah targets Congress on Vande Mataram

In 1950, the Constituent Assembly gave first two stanzas of Vande Mataram the same status as the national anthem, Jana Gana Mana, as the national song. Shah said that in 1937, Congress had "fragmented Vande Mataram into two parts" to appease Muslims. The home minister claimed this move helped the two-nation theory grow, which led to the country's partition. "When the mistake of fragmenting Vande Mataram occurred once, the nation suffered the consequences," Shah urged people to stand together against what he called the Congress party's ongoing politics of appeasement under Rahul Gandhi's leadership.

The home minister contrasted the Congress stance with the Narendra Modi Government's recent steps. Marking the 150th anniversary of the song's composition, the Government decided that the complete version of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's creation should be sung at all Government programmes and accorded legal backing, reportedly through an amendment related to the prevention of insults to national honour. Shah said the Congress had chosen to disregard this initiative, thereby insulting both the immortal work of Bankim *Babu* and the millions of martyrs who went to the gallows chanting Vande Mataram during the freedom struggle.

Bankim Chandra Chatterjee wrote Vande Mataram, and it first appeared in the novel Anandamath.

Congress leaders have supported the CWC's decision to stick with the 1937 position. Party general secretary KC Venugopal said the choice follows the agreement of freedom movement leaders like Gandhi, Nehru, Tagore, Subhas Chandra Bose, and Sardar Patel, and that Congress members will sing only the first two stanzas. Senior leader Jairam Ramesh called the BJP's criticism a distraction from current issues and said that both the national anthem and the national song remain important to the Congress.

Talks on water crises, delimitation dominate southern council meet

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chennai

In a high-stakes session underscoring the immediate need for coordinated action, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday chaired the 31st Southern Zonal Council meeting near Mahabalipuram in Tamil Nadu. The session focused on the urgent need for coordinated action. Chief ministers and senior officials from the southern states discussed long-standing crises that need quick solutions, including inter-state water disputes that threaten farmers' livelihoods.

The meeting addressed concerns about how parliamentary delimitation could affect the region's political influence. Leaders also discussed delays in justice for crimes against women and children, as well as ongoing funding problems that could harm the South's economy.

Education policy bottlenecks, critical infrastructure gaps and unresolved issues from the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act. The meeting also addressed problems in education policy, infrastructure gaps, and unresolved issues from the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act. Held at Taj Fisherman's Cove in Kovalam and hosted by the Tamil Nadu Government, the event brought together leaders who agreed these problems need immediate attention.

The Southern Zonal Council, created in 1956, is the main advisory group for Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, and the Union Territories of Puducherry, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and Lakshadweep. Amit Shah chaired the meeting, with Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay as vice-chairman.

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, Andhra



Union Home Minister Amit Shah, center, Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay, fourth left, Andhra Pradesh CM N Chandrababu Naidu, fourth right, Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar, third left, Keralam Chief Minister VD Satheesan, third right, and others during the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council (SZC), in Mahabalipuram in Chengalpattu district, Tamil Nadu

Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, and Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan attended in person.

Telangana was represented by Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, as Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy was abroad. Senior ministers and officials from both the states and the Central Government also took part evening, at the venue, the Tamil Nadu chief minister formally welcomed the Union Home Minister amid the gravity of the agenda. Water security occupied centre stage as leaders pressed for rapid movement on disputes that continue to fuel tension and uncertainty.

The Cauvery water-sharing agreement between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, and the proposed Mekedatu dam, were highlighted as urgent issues. Shivakumar said the project would benefit farmers in both states and Puducherry, and called for joint action soon.

Leaders also raised safety and operational concerns about the Mullaperiyar dam and unresolved Krishna River issues, saying they need quick technical and

political solutions.

Naidu stressed the importance of accelerating the Godavari-Cauvery river-linking plan to secure additional water and prevent future shortages in the South. Tamil Nadu officials repeated the need to protect existing rights and improve daily coordination between states. The issue of delimitation was also seen as urgent.

Shivakumar asked the council to recommend that the Union Government use the 1971 Census as the basis for redrawing constituencies, maintain the Lok Sabha at 543 seats for the next 25 years, and include women's reservation in this plan. Southern leaders warned that using newer population data could weaken the region's voice in Parliament and called for clear protections.

Participants said Fast Track Special Courts must be improved to speed up investigations and trials for rape and related crimes against women and children. They discussed gaps in how these courts work and called for more support so they can operate fully.

States asked for a larger share of resources, citing the

South's large contribution to national GDP and warning that insufficient funding could slow growth and undermine public services. Education issues were also discussed, with Tamil Nadu asking for more flexibility in medical admissions beyond the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test and pushing for a quick solution.

Leaders also looked at urgent needs in industrial investment, logistics, power grid connections, disaster readiness, and tourism infrastructure. They noted that unresolved issues arising from the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act and border coordination between Tamil Nadu and Karnataka require prompt administrative action.

During the four-hour meeting, leaders from both ruling and opposition states agreed that urgent action is needed. Although the council's recommendations are advisory, everyone recognised that unresolved issues over water, representation, and resources could harm regional stability and national progress. Officials said follow-up actions would start right away.

Shah visits West Bengal to review border issues

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

In what was being viewed as an enhanced effort to ensure peaceful law and order situation in view of recent socio-political developments an additional 50 companies of central forces were being deployed in West Bengal.

The forces that were likely to come in 3-4 days' time would double the existing post poll deployment from 50 to 100 companies.

Though there was no official statement from any quarter sources in the State Government said that the additional forces were being deployed in view of the coming festive seasons.

The central forces comprising jawans of Central Armed Police Force, Seema Suraksha Bal and Border

Security Force would "assist the State police in maintaining law and order during the festive season and would be distributed in all the 32 police districts including Kolkata," sources said refusing to comment on any intelligence input about any possible law and order issues during the Durga Pujas.

The decision of enhanced deployment of central forces comes in tandem with the visit of Union Home Minister Amit Shah to the State.

Shah was likely to reach Siliguri late on Thursday evening when his three-day visit to Bengal would commence. The Home Minister was likely to inaugurate a 'Law Exhibition' organised by the Union government at Kawakhal ground on Friday. Chief Minister Suwendu



Adhikari too was likely to attend the programme.

Shah was also expected to chair a border-security review meeting on August 22, sources said adding the purpose of the meeting was to evaluate the coordination among the BSF, SSB, intelligence agencies and state authorities.

His visit assumes significance in the backdrop of

rising importance of Siliguri corridor — also called chicken's neck — in view of the changing political situation in some neighbouring countries. "Chicken's Neck", an approximately 20-km wide stretch connecting rest of India with the North East is strategically important because of its proximity to neighbouring countries like Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh and China.

There will be high-level reviews of international security, an official said adding his visit was a continuation of the steps the Centre was taking to strengthen border security in the eastern side of the country. This was the second visit of the Home Minister after the BJP Government came to power in Bengal.

8 hurt as ABVP, Left students fight in Jadavpur University campus

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

All hell broke loose in and around the elite Jadavpur University (JU) campus following clashes between the supporters of Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and Left students' wings including the CPI(M) students' arm Students Federation of India.

The clashes that started during the midnight intervening Wednesday and Thursday and continued intermittently on Thursday left several supporters of both sides injured, police said. None had so far been arrested.

According to sources the ruckus started when alleged ABVP supporters entered the JU campus to protest against an ongoing meeting of — a defunct — Students' Governing Body asking how the Left wing students' unions could call a GB meeting when there was no elected students' union in any educational institution of the State.



Left-leaning student organizations, including SFI and AIDSO, hold a counter-protest banner reading 'JU Against Saffron' and shout slogans at the Jadavpur University campus following tensions and clashes with ABVP members in Kolkata, West Bengal on Thursday

Flags were set on fire and some University properties including an emblem — crafted by renowned artist of the yesteryear Nandalal Bose — fixed on the main gate was pulled down and damaged even as supporters from both sides of the main gate indulged in sloganeering.

Bottles and egg-hurling — which become a leitmotif of recent politics in the State — was resorted too even as the police had a trying time to

manage rival groups locking horns ferociously.

As Wednesday night's violence spilled onto streets on Thursday with the rival groups engaging in a show of strength taking out rallies and counter rallies, local BJP MLA Sarbori Mukherjee demanded immediate arrest of the "Maoists and Leninists."

About eight students had to be admitted to the nearby KPC medical college and

hospital, sources said adding both the sides were demanding arrest of the members of the rival camps.

When contacted Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya denied any BJP hand in the conflict saying, "ABVP is not a students' organization of the BJP unlike the SFI or DSO which are controlled by the CPI(M) and SUCI... so the BJP will not take any responsibility of whatever happened."

"The ABVP brought goons from outsider and tried to set JU afire last night... we want them arrested .," Dipshita Dhar an SFI leader of JNU fame said. ABVP leaders however blamed the Left for resorting to violence against peaceful protest. Later Bengal Minister and a former JU student Agnimitra Paul said, "I pray for the speedy recovery of ABVP student Nikhil Das and everyone injured at Jadavpur University," adding "the ideological battle against "Dimagi Naxals" will continue."

Ex-Congress MP Sajjan, convicted in 1984 anti-Sikh riots, dies at 80 in hospital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former Congress MP Sajjan Kumar, who was convicted for his role in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots case, died on Thursday at 80. Kumar, who was serving a life sentence in Delhi's Tihar Jail in riot-related cases, was declared brought dead at Safdarjung Hospital. Kumar, an influential Jat leader, was identified by the Delhi Police as the key instigator in the anti-Sikh riots that erupted across Delhi and parts of north India following the assassination of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards on October 31, 1984.

Supreme Court was scheduled to hear his plea on Thursday seeking three-week parole on medical grounds concerning his ailing wife. The jailed former parliamentarian had approached the top court seeking parole for three weeks, citing the medical condition of his ailing wife.

"Sajjan Kumar, aged 84 years, was brought to VMCC and Safdarjung Hospital by police with altered sensorium around 11 am. He was immediately admitted and resuscitation measures were initiated," the hospital said in a statement. "Despite pro-



Former Congress MP Sajjan Kumar has died, Safdarjung Hospital authorities confirmed on Thursday. Kumar is seen during an event at Rajghat in New Delhi in this file photo

viding all necessary medical and life-support measures, he could not be saved and passed away at 12:30 pm," it said. "He was a known case of high blood pressure and Parkinson's disease and had a history of multiple hospital admissions in the past," the statement said. He was lodged in Tihar Jail.

For more than 30 years, Kumar was not named as an accused. Interestingly, Kumar's name did not appear in the statements of several commissions that investigated the riots, including the Justice Ranj Nath Misra Commission and the Jain-Aggarwal panel. However, things changed in 2015 when the BJP govern-

ment set up an SIT to re-examine closed anti-Sikh riot cases.

A three-term Lok Sabha member, Kumar represented the Outer Delhi constituency and had been a prominent Congress leader. He resigned from the party after his 2018 conviction. For over three decades, Kumar faced multiple criminal cases relating to the violence, with outcomes that swung between acquittals and convictions across different courts.

On December 17, 2018, the Delhi High Court overturned a trial court's 2013 verdict acquitting Kumar in the case. He was subsequently convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment.

The riots broke out after the assassination of former prime minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards - Satwant Singh and Beant Singh - on October 31, 1984. Groups of armed men targeted Sikhs across Delhi and attacked their houses and shops. Over 3,000 Sikhs were killed across India, mostly in the national capital.

Kumar began his political career as a municipal councillor from Delhi's Nangloi in 1977. At the time, he was also the general secretary of the Pradesh Congress Committee. He was among the close allies of Indira Gandhi's younger son, Sanjay Gandhi. Kumar rose through the political ranks and won the Outer Delhi Lok Sabha seat in the 1980 elections. He defeated Chaudhary Brahm Prakash, Delhi's first chief minister. However, the aftermath of the 1984 riots brought his political career to a halt after he was accused of being criminally responsible for the violence. He withdrew from public glare and continued contributing to the party from behind the scenes. After a long gap, he returned to active politics, winning re-election to the Lok Sabha for a second term in 1991, and again in 2004.

PM meets Japanese minister, boosting India-Japan ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Defence Minister of Japan Shinjiro Koizumi on Thursday called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi who outlined his vision for further strengthening the Special Strategic and Global Partnership between the two countries.

During the meeting, Modi recalled his detailed discussions with Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi during her visit to India for the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit in July 2026 and appreciated the steady momentum in defence collaboration between the two countries.

"Japan's Minister of Defence Shinjiro Koizumi, who is on an official visit to India, called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi today," a statement issued by the Prime Minister's Office said. Modi outlined his vision for



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a meeting with the Defence Minister of Japan, Shinjiro Koizumi in New Delhi

further strengthening the Special Strategic and Global Partnership between India and Japan and highlighted the importance of India-

Japan defence and security cooperation in furthering peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond, the statement said.

Later, in a post on X, the prime minister said he was pleased to receive Defence Minister of Japan Shinjiro Koizumi.

"Had an excellent conversation on deepening defence and security ties between India and Japan. Our Special Strategic and Global Partnership is an important anchor for peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond," Modi said.

The prime minister outlined opportunities for Japan to partner with Indian companies and start-ups in the defence sector, particularly for co-development and co-production under 'Make in India' initiative.



भारत निर्वाचन आयोग
Election Commission of India



CHIEF ELECTORAL
OFFICER, HARYANA

SIR 2026

विशेष गहन पुनरीक्षण

हरियाणा

आपका मत, आपकी पहचान - हर संकल्प

फॉर्म-6

नए मतदाता के लिए

यदि आप 18 वर्ष की आयु पूर्ण कर चुके हैं और आपका नाम मतदाता सूची में नहीं है, तो फॉर्म-6 भरें।



नया नाम जोड़ने हेतु

फॉर्म-7

नाम हटाने के लिए

यदि किसी का नाम स्थानांतरित हो गया है, मृत्यु हो गई है या दोहराव है, तो फॉर्म-7 भरें।



नाम हटाने हेतु

फॉर्म-8

विवरण सुधारने के लिए

यदि आपके नाम, आयु, पता, फोटो या अन्य विवरण में कोई गलती है, तो फॉर्म-8 भरें।



विवरण सुधारने हेतु

उपरोक्त किसी भी फॉर्म के साथ आवश्यक दस्तावेज एवं घोषणा-पत्र संलग्न करें।

फॉर्म एवं आवश्यक दस्तावेज जमा करने के विकल्प



ऑनलाइन
voters.eci.gov.in
के माध्यम से

या



अपने क्षेत्र के
ERO / AERO कार्यालय में
व्यक्तिगत रूप से

विशेष अभियान की तिथियाँ



22-23 अगस्त, 2026

विशेष कैम्पेन दिवस



29-30 अगस्त, 2026

विशेष कैम्पेन दिवस

30/08/2026 तक जमा करें

लोकतंत्र को बनाएं और मजबूत



अधिक जानकारी के लिए
टोल फ्री नंबर
1950



ECINET ऐप डाउनलोड करें
नवीनतम जानकारी पाएं



मतदाता सूची देखें
voters.eci.gov.in



States Focus



GURU RAVIDAS' TEACHINGS GUIDE HUMANITY, SAYS HARYANA CM

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday said Guru Ravidas' vision of a society free from sorrow, injustice and discrimination continues to guide humanity, and called for his teachings of equality, service and social harmony to be put into practice.

Saini was speaking at a ceremony for the installation of Guru Ravidas' idol and inauguration of a newly built temple dedicated to him at Jadaula village in Kaithal district.

Union Minister for Law and Justice Arjun Ram Meghwal and former Rajya Sabha MP and programme coordinator Ishwar Singh were also present. (PTI)



GEN DHIRAJ SETH MEETS INDIAN ARMY VETERANS FROM NEPAL

Army Chief Gen Dhiraj Seth interacted with several Indian Army veterans in Pokhara, Nepal, reflecting the enduring bond of camaraderie and mutual respect between the force and the people of the Himalayan nation, officials said on Thursday.

These veterans had earlier served in the Indian Army and the interaction took place on Wednesday, a senior official said.

Gen Seth concluded his four-day official visit to Nepal on Wednesday during which he met the country's top leadership and discussed ways to expand the bilateral defence cooperation. (PTI)

Students now coming out to express themselves, this cannot be stopped anymore, says Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday said students are now coming out to express themselves and this cannot be stopped, as he urged them to use this energy for bringing fundamental changes for the country's youths.

Addressing an event to mark the birth anniversary of his father, former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi, he said Mahatma Gandhi's vision of India to enable everyone to tread the path of 'swaraj' can be achieved only if the Government opens the doors to the young people and the country helps them walk on that path.

The leader of opposition in Lok Sabha also accused the BJP-RSS of attacking minorities, taking away the land of tribals and oppressing Dalits, saying these need to be reversed.

"The job of the Government and the country is to open the doors to your imagination and to make you feel and believe and



LoP in the Lok Sabha and Congress MP Rahul Gandhi addresses 'Hara Bhara Swaraj: A Tribute to Rajiv Gandhi's Vision' on the birth anniversary of former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi, at Jawahar Bhawan in New Delhi

have the confidence that what truth is for them... The country should help you walk on that path. That is Gandhi's vision for India, and that is the path of Swaraj.

"This is the political fight taking place in India. The students are saying we have an expression and we believe in certain things as individuals. I am very proud now that

US envoy Sergio Gor visits Ladakh triggering China watch

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

After triggering a diplomatic firestorm in Srinagar by calling Jammu and Kashmir an 'important part of India', the United States Ambassador to India, Sergio Gor, landed in Leh on Thursday. His scheduled arrival at Leh was delayed due to bad weather conditions. On his arrival, the US Envoy was escorted under tight security cover to The Grand Dragon Hotel in Leh.

The visit assumes added significance because the Union Territory shares borders with China (Tibet Autonomous Region) and Pakistan.

Beijing authorities are closely monitoring the presence of a US diplomat in the cold desert region after he endorsed India's longstanding position on Jammu and Kashmir in Srinagar on Wednesday.

After a brief halt at the hotel, Gor began his tour by first visiting the Sangam Confluence at Nimmu, a



US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor's convoy arrives in Leh, Ladakh on Thursday

popular tourist destination far away from the stalking media persons. According to reports, the US Envoy also participated in river rafting along the Zaskar-Indus stretch, covering several kilometres from Tsogti.

This is the first visit of any top US diplomat to Ladakh after the region was carved out as a separate union territory in 2019 and a subsequent standoff between the Indian Army and Chinese PLA following clashes at Galwan in June 2020.

The US had strongly backed India and also condemned China's attempt to change the status quo at the Line of Actual Control in Ladakh.

During the standoff period, the US helped India with real-time intelligence and high-altitude gear for soldiers as part of a strategic defence partnership between the two countries.

Ahead of Sergio Gor's visit to Ladakh, speculations were rife in Leh about his meeting with the Tibetan spiritual

leader, the Dalai Lama, currently camping in Leh.

Till late evening, no such meeting took place. Every year, the Dalai Lama travels from Dharamshala to Leh and conducts regular religious discourses and meets followers.

Meanwhile, Vinai Kumar Saxena, the Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh on Thursday called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi and briefed him on the progress of key developmental initiatives.

In a post on X, the Office of LG Ladakh posted, "It was indeed an honour to call on Prime Minister @narendramodi and brief him on the progress of key developmental initiatives, infrastructure projects and the implementation of central welfare schemes in UT of Ladakh. Extremely grateful to the PM for his vision, constant guidance and support for the inclusive and sustainable development of Ladakh".

Ladakh taps 90m litres glacier water daily to irrigate 1,000 acres

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Led by the Lieutenant Governor, Vinai Kumar Saxena, the Union Territory of Ladakh has successfully started utilising a massive 90 million litres of glacier water per day for sustainable water and agricultural security in Ladakh.

Previously lost as untapped runoff into the River Indus, this colossal volume of glacial-melt water from Stok village Nallah in Leh is now being directly channelised into the Igloo-Phey Irrigation Canal, catering to nearly 12 villages and augmenting irrigation of over 1000 acres of barren

land that earlier remained parched due to paucity of water in the canal.

This landmark initiative uses simple earthwork to channelise and utilise the glacial runoff, without incurring any capital expenditure. This comes as a historic step toward transforming the region's agricultural productivity and realising the vision of a Green, Water-Secure, and Self-Sustaining Ladakh.

While Ladakh is endowed with abundant glacier and snowmelt resources, vast stretches of its cultivable land have historically faced acute irrigation shortages.

The imbalance between the large volumes of



untapped, draining water and the parched agricultural lands has, for ages, constrained rural livelihoods.

Recognising this critical gap, during his visits to various villages, L-G VK Saxena ideated and spearheaded a compre-

hensive, systematic campaign by identifying such places where large quantities of glacier water are flowing down the Indus River.

To ensure that every drop of glacier and snowmelt is harnessed for productive use

rather than going to waste, the Lieutenant Governor first identified Stok village Nallah as one such place for diverting the glacier water into the existing canal. The Stok Nallah is fed by the Stok Kangri Glacier near Leh.

On the directions of L-G Saxena on the 14th of August, the Irrigation and Flood Control Department successfully diverted excess glacier water from the main water channel of Nallah to the Igloo-Phey Canal by creating two trenches using a JCB.

"By successfully saving 90 million litres of glacier water daily and diverting this huge volume of water from the Stok Nallah into the Igloo Phey

and Yokyur canals, we have proven that large-scale, sustainable water management is entirely feasible in our cold desert. This is a monumental step toward our vision of a Green, Water-Secure, and Self-Sustaining Ladakh. Our administration's unwavering commitment is to harness every single drop for irrigation. This successful model is just a blueprint. We will expand these cost-effective interventions across Ladakh, transforming scattered glacier flows into a permanent lifeline for agricultural prosperity, revitalised rural economies, and long-term climate resilience for the people of Ladakh," said LG, Saxena.



Congress President and LoP in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge, party MP and LoP in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson and MP Sonia Gandhi, party MPs Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, KC Venugopal and others during the tribute paying ceremony of former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi on the latter's 82nd birth anniversary, also known as Sadbhavana Diwas (Harmony Day) at Samvidhan Sadan in New Delhi on Thursday

Chhattisgarh's Nari Shakti model: Women take centre stage in governance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

Chhattisgarh is emerging as a striking example of women's leadership in public administration, with the Vishnu Deo Sai Government steadily increasing the representation of women officers in key positions across the State.

The latest administrative reshuffle announced on Tuesday has further strengthened this trend. With the appointment of Jayashree Jain as Collector of Sakti district and Tanuja Salam as Collector of Mohla-Manpur-Ambagarh Chowki, Chhattisgarh now has 12 Women Collectors among its 33 districts, more than one-third of the State's districts.

The latest reshuffle also saw Tulika Prajapati, already serving as a Woman Collector,

move to Kabirdham district.

The development assumes significance because the Collector is the administrative face of the Government at the district level, responsible for coordinating development programmes, revenue administration, law & order and delivery of public services.

The latest appointments build on a broader administrative shift initiated earlier this year. In May, the Vishnu Deo Sai Government had placed women officers in charge of 10 districts, including Bemetara, Kondagaon, Narayanpur, Surajpur, Balarampur-Ramanujganj, Mohla-Manpur-Ambagarh Chowki, Balod, Koriya, Manendragarh-Chirmiri-Bharatpur and Sarangarh-Bilaigarh.

The message from the State's bureaucracy is



equally significant at the secretariat level. Niharika Barik, a senior IAS officer, heads the Home and Jail Department as Principal Secretary, a position carrying responsibility for one of the State's most critical admin-

istrative portfolios.

The latest reshuffle, which involved 22 IAS officers and an Indian Forest Service officer, has consequently acquired significance beyond a routine exercise in administrative postings.

Six districts ie Kanker, Mungeli, Sakti, Kabirdham, Gariaband and Mohla-Manpur-Ambagarh Chowki received new Collectors, with Women Officers taking charge of Sakti, Kabirdham and Mohla-Manpur-Ambagarh

Chowki. The posting of Women Officers to other important positions in the same order includes Roma Srivastava IAS as Chief Executive Officer, District Panchayat Sarguja; Akansha Shikha IAS as Director, Sports & Youth Welfare and Leena Kosam IAS as Commissioner, Municipal Corporation Durg.

For the Vishnu Deo Sai Government, the growing presence of women in Senior Administrative positions is consistent with its emphasis on Nari Shakti and women-centric Governance.

The State has also designated 2026 as 'Mahtari Gaurav Varsh', underlining the Government's focus on women's dignity, participation and empowerment.

What makes the Chhattisgarh experiment noteworthy is that women

officers are not being confined to departments traditionally associated with women and social welfare.

They are increasingly being entrusted with district administration, home affairs, revenue, urban development and other core governance responsibilities.

The significance goes beyond numbers. Having women in positions of authority can send a powerful message to young women across the State that leadership in public institutions is not restricted by gender.

At the district level, where Government policies directly meet citizens, the visibility of women administrators can also create new role models for girls aspiring to careers in civil services and public leadership.

The latest postings therefore represent more than an

administrative reshuffle. They signal an evolving governance philosophy in which women's empowerment is increasingly being reflected not only in welfare schemes but also in the structure and functioning of the administration itself.

With 12 of its 33 districts now led by Women Collectors and a Senior Woman IAS Officer heading the Home Department, Chhattisgarh is placing itself among the States drawing national attention for its growing representation of women in the higher echelons of governance.

For a State seeking to combine administrative reform with inclusive development, the rise of Nari Shakti in the bureaucracy could become an important part of its larger governance story.



100 DAYS OF PROGRESS

A RENEWED MANDATE BOOSTS ASSAM

Assam has completed the first 100 days of its renewed mandate with a clear focus on development, delivery and public welfare. From May 12 to August 20, 2026, the State Government, guided by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, has worked to translate its mandate into decisive action

and strengthen the foundations of a more prosperous and inclusive Assam.

The first 100 days have focused on accelerating infrastructure and connectivity while creating more opportunities for employment and enterprise. The Government has also focused on empowering women, strengthening social

welfare, and advancing key sectors such as education and healthcare.

Alongside these priorities, efforts to support farmers and rural livelihoods reflect a wider commitment to ensuring that development reaches communities across the State.

Assam's culture, heritage and identity remain an important

part of this development journey. The Government's Stated priorities seek to balance economic progress with preserving the State's distinctive cultural character. The renewed mandate also highlights the importance of responsive governance and a strong Centre-State partnership in taking Assam forward. Together, these

efforts aim to build a more prosperous, inclusive, and future-ready State. As Assam moves ahead, the first 100 days represent a period of decisive action and renewed confidence, with the Government reiterating its commitment to development and public welfare and placing the people's trust at the centre of its responsibility.

THE TRUST OF THE PEOPLE IS OUR STRENGTH; THE DEVELOPMENT OF ASSAM IS OUR RESPONSIBILITY

— HIMANTA BISWA SARMA
Assam Chief Minister

CM meets PM Modi, discusses flood recovery and development agenda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday met Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Sewa Teerth in South Block and discussed the State's ongoing flood recovery efforts, reconstruction plans and broader development priorities.

During the meeting, Sarma briefed the Prime Minister on Assam's roadmap for the next phase of the flood response, with a focus on rebuilding damaged areas, restoring livelihoods and ensuring comprehensive rehabilitation of people affected by the devastating floods.

In a post on X after the meeting, Sarma said Modi had remained in close touch throughout the flood crisis, regularly reviewing the situation and extending assistance to the State.

Sarma said the Prime Minister reaffirmed the Centre's continued support

for Assam's recovery efforts and assured that the Government of India would stand with the State until the rehabilitation and reconstruction mission reaches its logical conclusion.

The Chief Minister also apprised Modi of key initiatives undertaken by the Assam Government during its first 100 days in office to fulfil the mandate given by the people of the State.

The discussions also covered Assam's wider development agenda, including accelerating economic growth, strengthening infrastructure, improving public service delivery and creating greater opportunities for the people.

Expressing gratitude to the Prime Minister, Sarma said his continued guidance and commitment would help advance the shared vision of a "Viksit Assam". The meeting underscored the close coordination between the Centre and the Assam Government on flood management, rehabilitation and the State's long-term development priorities.

Sarma reiterated that his Government would continue to work closely with the Centre to ensure effective reconstruction in flood-affected areas while pursuing Assam's broader development goals.



PM Narendra Modi during a meeting with Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma in New Delhi PTI

Sarma takes up Jeevan Mission, Silsako Beel rejuvenation with Union Jal Shakti Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday met Union Jal Shakti Minister C R Paatil in the national capital and discussed strengthening water infrastructure and ensuring long-term water security in Assam.

The meeting, held at the Union Minister's official residence, was attended by officials of the Ministry of Jal Shakti and the Government of Assam.

During the meeting, Sarma discussed measures to strengthen the implementation of the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) in Assam and the ongoing rejuvenation of Silsako Beel, one of Guwahati's important urban wetlands. Highlighting the Centre's continued



support, the Chief Minister said the Jal Shakti Ministry has been a valuable partner in the ₹237-crore Silsako Beel rejuvenation project, which aims to restore the water-retention capacity of the wetland. The project is targeted for completion next year.

In a post on X following the meeting, Sarma said the Jal Shakti Ministry, under Paatil, has placed equal emphasis on expanding water infrastructure and ensuring long-term water security.

He said these priorities also shaped his discussions with the Union Minister, with particular focus on strengthening the Jal Jeevan Mission in Assam and expediting the rejuvenation of Silsako Beel.

The ₹237-crore project is aimed at improving the wetland's capacity to retain and reg-

ulate water, thereby contributing to flood mitigation and better management of Guwahati's urban water system.

Sarma expressed confidence that the collaboration between Assam and the Ministry of Jal Shakti would be further strengthened in the coming years.

"We look forward to extending this collaboration for the rejuvenation of urban water bodies and wetlands across Assam," the Chief Minister said in his post on X.

The Assam Government has been accord-ing priority to the conservation and rejuvenation of urban wetlands and water bodies as part of its broader efforts to strengthen flood management, improve water security and build climate-resilient urban infrastructure across the State.

Borders top priority for Govt: Rijiju on claims of Chinese intrusion in Arunachal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Thursday said border areas had been neglected in the past but were now a "top priority" of the Narendra Modi Government, as he sought to counter claims of fresh Chinese incursions in Arunachal Pradesh.

Rijiju also invoked former defence minister AK Antony's 2013 statement in Parliament, saying the Congress leader has then acknowledged India's historical policy of keeping border areas under-developed and that allowed China to steal a march over India in building infrastructure and capabilities along the frontier.

Antony, however, had also made it clear in the same speech that the policy had been abandoned 20 to 25 years earlier and said successive Indian Governments had since been strengthening



infrastructure and military capabilities in border areas. He had claimed that the UPA Government, then in its ninth year in office, had done the "maximum" to strengthen such capabilities.

The remarks by Rijiju, who represents Arunachal West in the Lok Sabha, come amid renewed concerns over Chinese military activity in the Upper Subansiri region of Arunachal Pradesh.

"Some people casually commented on border. Border areas are tough but @narendramodi govt is committed to border develop-

ment. I went to Maza, Galemo, Taksing areas in Arunachal Pradesh to speed up infrastructure works. Borders were neglected in the past but it's top priority now," Rijiju said in a post on X.

In a separate post, he targeted the Congress over its record on border infrastructure.

"Amongst the Congress leaders, AK Anthony ji is very honest. As Defence Minister he admitted the Congress Govt's policy of not making border infrastructure on the floor of the Parliament," he said.

Rijiju was referring to

Antony's remarks in the Lok Sabha on September 6, 2013, when the then defence minister acknowledged that China had built significantly better infrastructure along the border and attributed India's lag to a policy followed for decades after Independence.

Explaining the historical thinking behind the policy, Antony had said, "Independent India had a policy for many years that the best defence is not to develop the border. Undeveloped borders are safer than developed borders. So, for many years, there was no construction of roads or air fields on the border areas."

"By that time, China continued to develop their infrastructure in the border areas. So, as a result, they have now gone ahead of us. Compared to us, infrastructure-wise, capability-wise in the border areas, they are ahead. I admit that. It is a part of history," he had said.

ED raids 10 premises linked to Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in PMLA probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi/Lucknow

On Wednesday, the Lucknow Zonal Office of the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) searched 10 locations in Rampur, Saharanpur, and Delhi. These searches were part of an investigation under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, into claims of illegal land acquisition and the possible misuse of Government funds for the construction of Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur.

According to an ED, the investigation began after 26 First Information Reports (FIRs) were filed by Uttar Pradesh Police at Azeem Nagar Police Station in Rampur, along with another FIR at Kotwali Police Station in Rampur. These FIRs involve charges like extortion, cheating, forgery, and criminal conspiracy under the Indian Penal Code. Since these are considered scheduled offences



under the PMLA, the ED is allowed to investigate possible money laundering.

The FIRs and the ongoing investigation claim that Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur, led by Chancellor Mohd.

Azam Khan and others, illegally took land from local farmers and also acquired enemy property owned by the Government of India. The ED is now tracing the money trail, including how any proceeds of crime were generated, hidden, used, or turned into assets for the university. During the searches, offi-

cers seized various materials they believe are important to the investigation. These included incriminating documents, records of alleged fake donations linked to the university's Trust, and digital files.

All items were taken under the rules of the PMLA, 2002. The ED says these materials will help track the flow of funds and show if illegal money was disguised as legitimate assets. Mohammad Ali Jauhar University has already been investigated before by State authorities over related issues. The ED is now focus-

ing only on the financial side of the alleged wrongdoing. Investigators are looking into how money from disputed land deals or alleged donations was used to build and develop the university, including whether any Government funds were misused.

The searches took place at several locations in Rampur, Saharanpur, and Delhi, showing that the investigation covers a wide area. This multi-location approach is standard for the ED when collecting records from different places connected to the same case.

The Enforcement Directorate has emphasised that the investigation is ongoing. More steps will be taken as they review the seized documents and digital evidence. Under the PMLA, the agency must identify, seize, and, if needed, confiscate assets gained from crime once money laundering is proven.

238 AC EMU trains for Mumbai suburban to be manufactured on priority: Vaishnaw

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Thursday said priority is being given to manufacture 238 air-conditioned electrical multiple unit (EMU) trains for Mumbai suburban.

These will be built at three production units — Integral Coach Factory (ICF) in Chennai, Tamil Nadu, Rail Coach Factory (RCF) in Kapurthala, Punjab, and Modern Coach Factory (MCF) in Raebareli, Uttar Pradesh.

"The step has been taken to ensure the timely availability of rolling stock in line with the commissioning of infrastructure under the



Mumbai Urban Transport Project (MUTP)," a Railway Ministry statement said.

"An indicative production programme provides for 120 AC EMU rakes through ICF, 71 rakes through RCF and 47 rakes through MCF, taking the total to 238 rakes," it added.

According to the ministry, Indian Railways' production units have proven capability in manufacturing modern passenger rolling stock, including air-conditioned EMUs, Vande Bharat and Vande Metro trains.

The Railway Board has approved procurement of the sanctioned AC EMU rakes on existing and proven specifications of the Research Designs and Standards Organisation and ICF, facilitating expeditious manufacturing and supply of the rolling stock.

The ministry said supply is planned to commence from 2027, with the entire sanctioned quantity scheduled for completion by 2030.

Jharkhand CM Soren vows to fight mines Bill on all democratic, legal fronts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Ranchi

Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Thursday said his Government would oppose the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, on every democratic, constitutional and legal front, alleging that the Centre passed it without taking States into confidence.

"The Centre has made changes to the MMDR Act that are highly adverse and truly unfortunate. These will seriously impact every tribal, Dalit, poor person, farmer and labourer in the State," Soren said while addressing reporters here.

The JMM president chaired the party's extended central



Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren, Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) leader Kalpana Soren and party legislators during the JMM Central Committee meeting to outline their opposition against the controversial Mining and Minerals Amendment Act 2026 Bill in Ranchi on Thursday PTI

committee meeting at Sohrai Bhawan here, where various issues, including the MMDR Bill, were discussed.

Soren questioned the Centre's decision to pass the

legislation without consulting State Governments and asked who would compensate States for the losses expected to arise from the changes.

"Who will compensate for

the massive losses that are bound to occur? It appears the central Government will not even compensate for past losses," he said.

Soren said Jharkhand had already submitted a claim to the Centre for outstanding dues of ₹1.36 lakh crore from coal companies.

Parliament passed the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, on August 13.

The legislation seeks to restrict States' powers to levy taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands.

"We strongly oppose it, and we will also fight battles against it at the democratic, constitutional, and legal levels," Soren said.

Soren alleged that the central Government appears

far more sensitive towards developed States and feels a greater sense of accountability towards them.

"There is absolutely no sign of empathy on the part of Adivasis, Dalits, or the backward classes," he said.

Terming it a matter of serious concern for Jharkhand's future, the CM said they will continue to discuss the matter and determine future strategy.

Earlier, Soren urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to reconsider the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, saying restrictions on State levies could significantly reduce the State's fiscal space and affect its ability to address the social and environmental costs of mining.



Editor's

TAKE

Fake medicine: A crime against humanity

The counterfeit-drug racket uncovered in Karnataka is a shocker. India needs stronger surveillance and harsher punishment for perpetrators

The recent bust of a large counterfeit-medicine operation near Bengaluru is not just another regulatory raid; it is a stark reminder that fake drugs are a slow-motion mass poisoning that demands the severest punishment and systemic reform. Karnataka's Food Safety and Drug Administration (FDA) enforcement wing raided an unlicensed facility at a farmhouse in Bidadi (Ramanagara district) and seized medicines, expired stock, counterfeit labels, packaging material and an injection-filling unit valued at about ₹4.91 crore. Officials allege that cheaper medicines sourced from other states were repackaged and relabelled to look like products of major multinational companies-including brands such as Pfizer-and then sold to hospitals and pharmacies at roughly 50 per cent below market price. Counterfeit medicines are not just another "white-collar" crime; they are a public-health assault. Patients in ICUs, cancer wards and chronic-disease clinics rely on exact dosages and sterility. Fake or substandard drugs can cause treatment failure, drug resistance, organ damage and death.

When criminals knowingly flood hospitals with relabelled injectables and critical medicines, they are effectively mass murderers operating for profit. Think of small children, old people and pregnant women being administered spurious medicines which are nothing less than poison. That moral culpability, multiplied across thousands of doses, meets the threshold of a crime against humanity. At the national level, regulators report that over 1.41 lakh drug samples were tested in 2025-26, with 3,012 declared "not of standard quality" and 283 spurious; 961 prosecution cases were filed in 2024-25 alone, a five-year high.

This itself shows the magnitude of this crime taking place across the country. In June 2026, CDSCO flagged 159 substandard drugs, and over five years more than 3,500 prosecution cases have been registered. Yet detections of spurious drugs have fallen even as prosecutions rise, suggesting either better legal follow-through or, worryingly, that many fakes never reach testing labs. The Bengaluru case exposes systemic gaps: unlicensed farmhouse units operating with relabelling lines, interstate sourcing, and deep discounts to hospitals indicate weak last-mile oversight and possible collusion. Past incidents-from fake cancer and diabetes medicines in Delhi (₹4 crore seizure in April 2024) to counterfeit antibiotics in Delhi-UP and large cough-syrup scandals-show a pattern of recurring networks with limited deterrence. Enforcement agencies deserve credit for the Bidadi raid, but the existence of such a sophisticated unit points to intelligence failures, fragmented state-centre coordination, and insufficient routine inspections of high-risk places.

Without real-time traceability, whistleblower protections, and harsher penalties, raids remain reactive. It is high time to make end-to-end track-and-trace mandatory for critical injectables and oncology drugs. The perpetrators of such heinous crimes deserve no mercy and should get the taste of their own medicine with the severest punishment.

Reimagining liberal arts in the era of AI

Liberal education equips students with the capacities needed to navigate a rapidly changing world by fostering creativity, ethical reasoning, interdisciplinary understanding, and adaptability. By integrating the humanities, social sciences, and professional disciplines, universities can cultivate sceptical and reflective minds capable of questioning assumptions



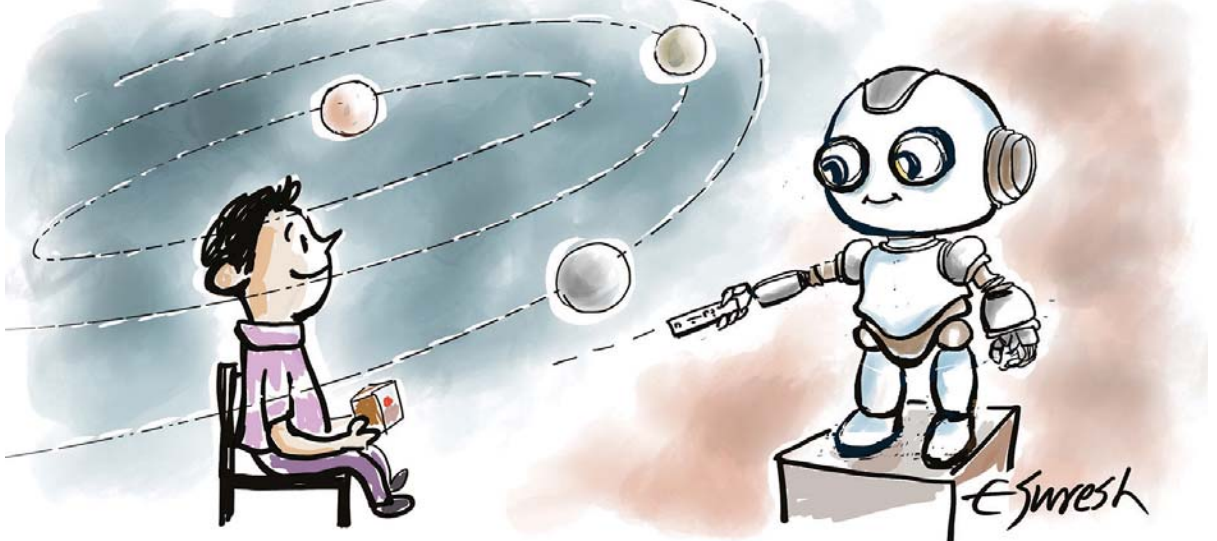
SURENDRA KUMAR YADAWA

As artificial intelligence rapidly reshapes the way knowledge is created, accessed, and applied, classrooms are evolving into 360-degree learning environments (students' total growth), where digital technologies, collaborative platforms, and intelligent systems increasingly influence how students learn and engage with the world. Amid this, a fundamental question emerges: should higher education focus solely on producing technically skilled professionals, or should it also cultivate reflective, ethical, and analytical minds? In India, the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 seeks to address this challenge by promoting multidisciplinary learning, curricular flexibility, and student-centred pedagogy, reaffirming that the purpose of higher education extends beyond employability to nurturing individuals who can think independently, communicate persuasively, and contribute meaningfully to society.

As learning behaviours evolve rapidly, education systems face the challenge of preparing students not merely to acquire information, but to interpret, question, and use it responsibly. In an age of smart technologies, AI should enhance human capabilities rather than replace them, making critical literacy, analytical reasoning, and the ability to ask meaningful questions increasingly valuable. Consequently, success will depend not merely on technical expertise but on the ability to scrutinise evidence critically, innovate creatively, collaborate effectively, and exercise problem-solving abilities guided by wisdom, empathy, and human values.

While integrating liberal learning with professional education, institutions can nurture adaptable, creative, and socially responsible graduates equipped to navigate complexity, exercise informed choice, and address the multifaceted challenges of society. In liberal arts education, historians, philosophers, political scientists, and sociologists encourage learners to question assumptions, examine evidence, and understand the complexities of human societies. Interdisciplinary learning fosters curiosity, critical thinking, and informed judgement - qualities difficult to replicate through technology. In an AI-driven era marked by misinformation and deepfakes, liberal education equips individuals to avoid the dangers of uncritical conformity (Hannah Arendt) in public life.

Indeed, true education brings out the innate talent of students. As the UGC underlines, knowledge, skills, attitudes and values are graduates' attributes that foster intellectual growth, creativity, and lifelong learning beyond memorisation.



THE CHALLENGES OF THE TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY DEMAND MORE THAN TECHNICAL PROFICIENCY; THEY REQUIRE HOLISTIC LEARNING THAT CULTIVATES DIGITAL DEMOCRACY BASED ON CURIOSITY AND CRITICAL INQUIRY

The writer is Assistant Professor of Political Science, School of Management and Liberal Arts, IMS Unison University, Dehradun

By encouraging inquiry, evidence-based reasoning, and interdisciplinary learning, institutions can empower students to navigate information critically and create civic trust. By integrating the humanities, social sciences, natural sciences and technology, institutions enable students to navigate complex realities, evaluate competing claims, and exercise ethical judgement.

Its purpose is not merely to acquire knowledge but to read critically, write cogently, think broadly and act wisely.

The challenges of the twenty-first century demand more than technical proficiency; they require holistic learning that cultivates digital democracy based on curiosity and critical inquiry. Historians teach the importance of evidence and context. Philosophers sharpen reasoning and expose logical fallacies; political scientists illuminate the workings of institutions and power; literature cultivates empathy and perspective-taking, while anthropologists reveal how culture shapes human behaviour.

Together, these disciplines foster the ability to question assumptions, evaluate competing claims, and engage thoughtfully with complex realities. In an era of information abundance and algorithmic decision-making, wisdom remains humanity's greatest strength, empowering individuals to exercise ethical judgement, maintain intellectual independence, critically evaluate information, participate responsibly in democratic processes, and engage meaningfully in community action.

Liberal education equips students with the capacities needed to navigate a rapidly changing world by fostering creativity, ethical reasoning, interdisciplinary understanding, and adaptability. By integrating the humanities, social sciences, and professional disciplines, universities can cultivate sceptical and reflective minds capable of questioning assumptions, evaluating evidence, and addressing complex techno-

logical, environmental, and societal challenges by drawing insights across disciplines rather than from specialisation alone. As knowledge becomes increasingly accessible, education must empower students to think globally.

In this era of rapidly evolving technology, students now study social sciences alongside artificial intelligence, combine data science with psychology, and understand environmental challenges from scientific, historical, and social perspectives. The liberal arts seek to cultivate technical competence as well as human ability, ethical judgement, creativity, and adaptability - qualities that remain uniquely human in an increasingly automated world.

A philosopher familiar with data science engages more effectively with contemporary challenges. A policymaker who understands artificial intelligence is better equipped to govern an increasingly digital society. The ideal graduate is neither only a specialist nor a traditional generalist but an interdisciplinary thinker who can connect knowledge across fields, adapt to complexity, and approach problems with both technical competence and human understanding.

The future of education cannot be defined by technological proficiency alone. In an age when information is abundant and AI can generate answers instantly, the real challenge is cultivating minds capable of questioning assumptions (Socrates), testing ideas through debate (J.S. Mill), and making wise choices.

A liberal arts education equips students with these enduring capacities by fostering intellectual curiosity, ethical reflection, creativity, and civic responsibility. As India aspires to become a global knowledge leader, its universities must nurture not only skilled professionals but also thoughtful citizens. The sceptical mind is no longer an academic ideal; it is the foundation of innovation, democratic vitality, and sustainable well-being.

PIC TALK



Workers transplant paddy saplings in a field, in Nadia district, West Bengal
PHOTO: PTI

We need to stop treating reinvention as a crisis



DEEBA IRFAN SALIM

2ND OPINION

There is a strange impatience with women as they grow older. At some point, the questions subtly change.

When we are young, people ask what you want to become. Later, they ask what you have achieved. And somewhere in the middle of life, the questions become quieter, but more loaded: What now? What are you going to do with yourself? Why are you starting again? Shouldn't you be slowing down?

I have often wondered why we think of reinvention as something that belongs exclusively to the young.

Perhaps because we have been taught to see life as a ladder. You climb it in your twenties and thirties, establish yourself in your forties, and by your fifties and sixties, you are expected to sit comfortably on whatever rung you have reached. But life isn't a ladder. It is much closer to a manuscript. And manuscripts can be rewritten. I have met women who, after decades of being mothers, wives, pro-

fessionals and caregivers, suddenly discover a version of themselves that had been waiting patiently underneath all those identities. Sometimes it emerges through writing. Sometimes through travel. Sometimes through a business, a friendship, a classroom, or simply the decision to wake up one morning and say: I want something different.

And almost invariably, there is guilt attached to it. Why? Because women have been conditioned to believe that their value lies in how useful they are to everyone else. We are taught to care before we are taught to create. To accommodate before we are taught to ask. To remember everyone's birthdays, appointments, preferences and anxieties, while quietly forgetting the things that still make us feel alive. Then one day, the children leave home. A career changes. A parent becomes dependent. A marriage enters a different phase. The body changes. Menopause arrives. The face in the mirror becomes unfamiliar. And suddenly, the old map doesn't work anymore.

This is often described as a midlife crisis. I think that phrase is unfair. Perhaps what we call a crisis is simply an awakening. There is grief in growing older. We lose people, versions of ourselves, and the illusion of unlimited time. Some losses permanently rearrange the furniture in our inner lives. But grief strips away pretence and asks what actually matters. Writing teaches us that healing is not always about forgetting what happened, but finding language for what the experience changed inside us. We live in a culture obsessed with productivity, but some things cannot be solved; they must be understood. Understanding

requires us to pause long enough to hear ourselves. We realize not every relationship has to be saved, not every rejection is a verdict, and some things simply end because they have completed their purpose. The greatest freedom of the second half of life is becoming less interested in being universally understood. Ageing should not be about becoming smaller. It should be about becoming more exact: fewer performances, fewer apologies, fewer obligations.

More truth. More curiosity. More courage to begin something without practical reasons. A woman in her twenties can reinvent herself; why can't a woman in her fifties or sixties write a book, learn to paint, start a company, fall in love, travel alone, return to university, or become someone she never had time to be?

We must stop asking women what they are doing next and ask what they have become brave enough to do. This stage is about what we leave behind-stories told, wisdom passed on, honest mistakes, books written, and the permissions we give others by refusing to disappear quietly.

I prefer continuing differently. Taking everything we lived through and allowing it to become material rather than memory. Turning grief into language, experience into wisdom, and loneliness into connection. This is the chapter where, finally, we get to write without asking anyone else what the story should be.

The writer is an award-winning, Dubai-based author exploring themes of memory, identity and emotional truth through storytelling, and is the founder of TheWriteScene.com

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



www.dailypioneer.com

facebook.com/dailypioneer @TheDailyPioneer
instagram.com/dailypioneer linkedin.com/in/ThePioneer

RESPECT AND DIALOGUE CAN REVIVE BILATERAL TIES

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's assurance that Bangladesh's Prime Minister would be accorded an honourable reception is a reassuring diplomatic signal. At a time when relations between the two neighbours need careful handling, such a gesture can help create an atmosphere of trust and reduce tensions.

India and Bangladesh share a common history, cultural affinities and extensive economic and people-to-people links. While differences are inevitable between neighbouring countries, they should be managed through regular consultations rather than allowing them to become lasting sources of friction.

The two sides should use every opportunity to discuss issues of mutual concern, including trade, connectivity, border management, water sharing and regional security. Constructive engagement can help

both countries protect their interests while ensuring that bilateral cooperation continues to benefit ordinary citizens.

The emphasis on an honourable reception reflects the value of diplomatic courtesy in international relations. India should continue to pursue dialogue and cooperation with Bangladesh so that existing challenges can be addressed peacefully and the relationship can move towards greater stability and mutual confidence.

Dialogue should remain the foundation of bilateral ties. Mutual respect, diplomatic sensitivity and sustained engagement can help both nations overcome differences and rebuild confidence. A stable India-Bangladesh relationship is important not only for the two countries but also for peace, prosperity and connectivity across the wider region.

RUKMA SHARMA | PUNJAB

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Potholes claim more lives

The tragic incident in which three children lost their lives after falling into a water-filled pit in Sehore district of Madhya Pradesh is deeply distressing. Such deaths are preventable and should never become routine. Authorities must act swiftly, before another family suffers further.

"Deaths due to potholes are unacceptable, the figures are probably more than those killed on border," a Supreme Court bench headed by Justice Madan B. Lokur observed in December 2018 while pursuing a statistical report on road accident deaths. Since then, much water has flown down the Thames, yet adequate corrective measures have not been made.

Earlier this month, in August 2026, the Free Press reported that Bhopal has nearly 500 potholes per kilometre. The figure is alarming and exposes the seriousness of the problem.

The Sehore tragedy should serve as a wake-up call for authorities. Roads and public spaces must be regularly inspected, dangerous pits immediately barricaded and repairs completed without delay. Citizens should not have to pay with their lives for administrative negligence. Authorities must learn from this tragedy and fix these road anomalies urgently.

TUSHAR ANAND | MADHYA PRADESH

India's test win offers lessons

Congratulations to the Indian cricket team for securing a 165-run victory in the Galle Test against Sri Lanka. The victory came largely through India's first-innings batting dominance and fourth-innings bowling performance.

The Indian batters piled up 462 runs in the first innings, thanks mainly to a brilliant 167 from Devdutt Padikkal and 84 from KL Rahul. In the second innings, Rishabh Pant's stroke-filled 66 enabled India to set the hosts a target of 372 runs. Manav Suthar was the standout performer with the ball, picking up 10 wickets in the match.

Playing domestic cricket is a prime reason for the success of Suthar and Padikkal. Moreover, India went in with a specialist spinner for the Galle Test. For Test matches, we need specialists. Gautam Gambhir must shed his inclination to select all-rounders in Test matches. India does not boast all-rounders of Kapil Dev's calibre.

As far as selection is concerned, selectors must encourage domestic players, recognise their performances and include them in Test matches when opportunities arise. The victory gave India a start to the series and 12 WTC.

S SANKARANARAYANAN | CHENNAI

The power of nuclear arms

Trump intends to call on Kim Jong Un again. Trump says Kim has 57 "very powerful" nuclear weapons. This helps us understand Trump's foreign policy: nuclear weapons command his respect.

Pakistan, a nuclear power with a troubling history of proliferation, consequently receives cautious and indulgent handling. Iran has oil but, crucially, no bomb, and this has proved a dangerous combination in the Middle East. Oil-rich but non-nuclear states have repeatedly found American interests overriding Washington's responsibility as a major power.

Russia possesses oil, nuclear weapons and a formidable military. China has nuclear weapons, economic power and military depth. Washington is careful with both. Ukraine, having inherited a substantial Soviet nuclear arsenal, foolishly surrendered it and is now paying a painful price. None of this makes nuclear weapons desirable or guarantees security. But they plainly alter the diplomatic equation. A nuclear arsenal may not make a country invulnerable, but it makes attacking it more complicated. The lesson is crude: oil makes you valuable but vulnerable; an army makes you dangerous; nuclear weapons compel negotiations. And now, Hormuz seems as good an alternative.

R NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

The long history of India’s changing relationship with nature

From the sacrifice of the Bishnois at Khejarli to the women of Chipko, India’s environmental history is also a history of people defending the ecosystems on which their lives depend. The question now is whether development can be pursued without severing that enduring bond between people and nature



BKP SINHA



ARVIND KUMAR JHA

For centuries, India’s landscapes have been shaped by communities whose lives and livelihoods have been closely connected to forests, rivers, mountains, wetlands, grasslands and wildlife. Forests, in particular, have sustained communities by providing food, fuel, fodder, fibres, fruits, medicinal plants, timber and water, while also supporting soils, water systems, local climates and biodiversity. For millions of forest-dependent communities, forests remain deeply woven into their livelihoods, traditions, customs and everyday lives.

Over generations, numerous communities across India developed customary practices to govern the use of forests, water sources, grazing lands and other common resources. Although these practices varied across regions, many were rooted in the understanding that human well-being is closely connected to the health of surrounding ecosystems. Sacred groves, community-protected forests, traditional water-harvesting systems and sustainable agricultural practices were among the ways in which communities conserved natural resources while meeting their livelihood needs.

This close relationship with nature also gave rise to a rich body of traditional ecological knowledge. Indigenous, tribal, and other forest-dependent communities developed a detailed understanding of local biodiversity through generations of observation and experience. They learned to identify plants and understand their seasonal availability, edible uses, medicinal properties, and other practical applications. Plants such as neem, tulsi, turmeric, ashwagandha, amla, giloy, and bael have long been used in various traditional medical systems and community practices. This accumulated knowledge has helped deepen our understanding of India’s remarkable botanical diversity and continues to form an important part of the cultural knowledge of many communities.

Certain trees, including peepal, banyan, neem, and bael (Aegle marmelos), have acquired religious and cultural significance in different communities and regions of India. Rivers such as the Ganga, Yamuna, Narmada, Godavari, and Kaveri have also become deeply embedded in cultural and religious traditions, with communities developing rituals and practices around these rivers.

Over time, however, this relationship underwent a profound transformation. Under British rule, forests were increasingly brought under state control and managed primarily for revenue generation and commercial timber production. The appointment of the German forester Dietrich Brandis as the first Inspector General of Forests in India in 1864 marked an important step towards establishing a centralised forest administration.

Environmental movements emerged as communities defended their close relationship with nature. The 1730 Khejarli sacrifice, when Amrita Devi Bishnoi and 363 Bishnois gave their lives protecting Khejri trees, remains a powerful example. Gandhi similarly advocated restraint, conservation and responsible consumption. The loss or restriction of customary access created economic hardship, disrupted traditional resource-use practices, and contributed to growing resentment against colonial forest policies. From the mid-nineteenth century onwards, the rapid expansion of the railway network created an enormous demand for timber, particularly for railway sleepers, bridges, buildings and other infrastructure, as well as for fuel for steam locomotives. To meet this growing demand, the colonial forest administration expanded timber extraction and brought increasingly large areas of forest under systematic management. In many regions, the colonial forest administration favoured economically valuable species and established monoculture plantations at the expense of diverse natural forests. Teak, deodar and sal, for example, were highly valued for their durability and suitability for shipbuilding, construction and other commercial uses. During the First and Second World Wars, pressure on forests intensified further as wartime requirements generated additional demand for timber,



ALTHOUGH INDIA HAS SUBSEQUENTLY STRENGTHENED ITS FOREST LAWS AND EXPANDED AFFORESTATION PROGRAMMES, CHALLENGES IN IMPLEMENTING AND ENFORCING THESE MEASURES HAVE LIMITED THEIR EFFECTIVENESS IN PROTECTING NATURAL FORESTS. MOREOVER, NEWLY PLANTED FORESTS CANNOT FULLY REPLACE ANCIENT NATURAL FORESTS THAT HAVE EVOLVED OVER CENTURIES AND CONTINUE TO SUPPORT COMPLEX ECOSYSTEMS AND RICH BIODIVERSITY.

The writers are Former PCCFs, UP and Maharashtra

fuelwood and other forest products.

After Independence, India faced widespread poverty, food shortages, and significant economic challenges that required rapid development. Large dams, mining projects, steel plants, transport infrastructure, thermal power stations, and agricultural expansion became national priorities. While these projects contributed to economic growth, they also accelerated the diversion and degradation of forests. In many cases, forest-dependent communities were displaced, often without adequate rehabilitation or alternative sources of livelihood, while wildlife habitats became increasingly fragmented. The Green Revolution significantly improved agricultural production and food security, but intensive farming in some regions also contributed to groundwater depletion, soil degradation, and greater reliance on chemical inputs.

Although India has subsequently strengthened its forest laws and expanded afforestation programmes, challenges in implementing and enforcing these measures have limited their effectiveness in protecting natural forests. Moreover, newly planted forests cannot fully replace ancient natural forests that have evolved over centuries and continue to support complex ecosystems and rich biodiversity.

The environmental movements that emerged across India were, in many ways, responses to the changing relationship between people and nature. Ecosystems have endured not only because of scientific knowledge or government policies, but also because ordinary people have regarded nature as integral to their lives and communities and shown extraordinary courage in protecting it. The Khejarli sacrifice of 1730, when Amrita Devi Bishnoi and 363 members of the Bishnoi community in Rajasthan gave their lives resisting the felling of Khejri trees, remains a powerful example. A similar philosophy is reflected in Mahatma Gandhi’s ideas, which emphasised restraint in the use of natural resources and cautioned against excessive consumption and unchecked industrialisation.

These concerns about unchecked development and the growing separation of human life from nature were also reflected in the ideas of Rabindranath Tagore. At Shantiniketan, Tagore sought to bring education closer to nature. In 1928, he introduced the Vriksharopana ceremony, encouraging people to celebrate trees and respect the environment. Decades later, these concerns found powerful expression through the Chipko Movement in the 1970s. Local villagers, particularly women, resisted commercial felling because their lives and livelihoods depended on forests. Activists such as Chandi Prasad Bhatt and Sunderlal Bahuguna helped mobilise support, while Gaura Devi and the women of Reni village became prominent figures. The movement highlighted the ecological and social importance of Himalayan forests and contributed to the government’s 1980 decision to impose a fifteen-year ban on commercial green felling in the Himalayan forests of Uttar Pradesh.

The struggle to protect nature, however, did not end with these movements. It continues today, as major development projects and resource extraction put pressure on India’s remaining natural ecosystems. The proposed Great Nicobar Island infrastructure project, coal mining in Chhattisgarh’s Hasdeo forests, and the Ken-Betwa river-linking project, which involves the submergence of forest areas in and around Panna Tiger Reserve, are a few examples of this continuing struggle. The true measure of development must therefore go beyond economic gains to account for forests lost, soils degraded, water depleted, and biodiversity diminished — costs that are ultimately borne by society and future generations.

If modern governance is to honour the legacy of those who gave their lives to protect nature, it must move beyond passive bureaucracy towards active stewardship — safeguarding native ecosystems, meaningfully involving tribal and forest-dependent communities and respecting their rights. This requires the same moral courage shown by earlier generations who stood in the path of the axe to protect their forests, so that India’s natural landscapes can be safeguarded for future generations.

Modi’s I-Day speeches: Shaping India’s future



PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

The goal was clear: move from financial exclusion to empowerment. In 2014, when Modi became “Pradhan Sevak,” he chose not to use a bulletproof shield and instead focused on issues such as sanitation, financial inclusion, and manufacturing. The Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) aimed to give every household a bank account. The Swachh Bharat Mission worked to end open defecation. Make in India encouraged global investment in local manufacturing, while the Saansad Adarsh Gram Yojana and the Housing for All program completed the first round of reforms.

These programs addressed long-standing poverty issues. By 2026, there were over 580 million Jan Dhan accounts with more than three trillion rupees in deposits. Direct Benefit Transfers (DBT) sent welfare funds straight to people’s bank accounts.

The Swachh Bharat Mission resulted in the construction of over 120 million household toilets, and India was declared open-defecation-free. Make in India delivered strong results: electronics manufacturing grew nearly sevenfold, mobile phone production increased 35-fold, and defence production also rose. The PM Awas Yojana (PMAY) led to the construction of millions of permanent homes. Electricity reached villages for the first time. In 2015, Modi’s speech introduced Startup India and Stand Up India to support young entrepreneurs, especially women and people from Scheduled Castes and Tribes. The One Rank One Pension (OROP) scheme met a long-standing demand from the armed forces and brought pension equality. India now has over 250,000 startups, creating millions of jobs and making the country the world’s third-largest startup hub. The focus then shifted to healthcare and space. Ayushman Bharat gave each family health coverage worth 500,000 rupees, and the Gaganyaan mission aimed to send an Indian astronaut to space by 2022. More than 450 million Ayushman cards have been issued, helping millions get free medical care. Although the Gaganyaan schedule changed, by 2026, important progress had been made with human-rated systems and uncrewed missions.

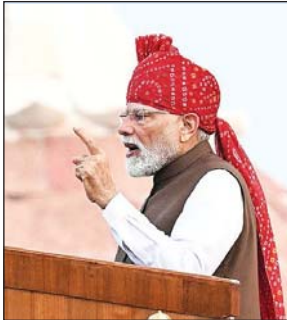
In 2019, Modi’s speech focused on making water more accessible and improving military coordination. The Jal Jeevan Mission promised to bring working tap water to every rural home, increasing coverage from 17 per cent to over 81 per cent and reaching more than 158 million homes by early 2026. Creating the Chief of Defence Staff role helped the armed services work together more effectively. The COVID pandemic years were challenging. In 2020, Modi launched the National Digital Health Mission and stressed Atmanirbhar Bharat, or self-reliant India. In 2021, the Gati Shakti plan was launched as a major infrastructure project worth 100 trillion rupees, alongside the National Hydrogen Mission. Roads, railways, and logistics grew quickly, and renewable energy expanded rapidly.

India’s renewable energy capacity grew from 76.38 GW in 2014 to 288.58 GW by June 2026, nearly fourfold. Solar power saw the biggest increase, rising from about 2.8 GW to 162.15 GW, then to around 164.6 GW. Wind power went from about 21 GW to 57.44 GW. Hydropower reached 57.24 GW, and bio-power was at 11.75 GW. By July 2026, non-fossil fuel sources made up over 300 GW, or more than 54 per cent of all installed power capacity. Clean energy output more than doubled, from 191 billion units in 2014-15 to nearly 478 billion units in 2025-26.

Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in the sector reached 45.72 billion dollars, and domestic institutions invested 12.32 lakh crore rupees. From 2022, the focus moved to long-term goals for 2047. The Panch Pran pledges called for a developed India free from colonial mindsets. In 2023, Modi set a goal to create two crore “Lakhpati Didis.” By 2026, more than 20 million women earned over 100,000 rupees a year through self-help groups. In 2024, the PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana helped families install rooftop solar panels by giving up to 80,000 rupees per household. The program reached over 5 million households, adding almost 15 GW of rooftop solar capacity. Nearly 1.9 million families now pay nothing for electricity, and many sell extra power to earn more. Adding 75,000 medical seats over five years began to address the doctor shortage. In 2025, Modi announced the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana, a one-trillion-rupee plan to create 35 million jobs. Mission Sudarshan Chakra set a 2035 deadline for a new air-defence system. India also made progress in producing its own semiconductors, with the first home-grown chips reaching the market. GST reforms were announced as a Diwali gift.

In 2026, on the 80th Independence Day and during his thirteenth consecutive speech, Modi introduced ‘Sapta Dhara’, or seven pillars of national strength: manufacturing, agriculture and food processing, technology and innovation, Gati Shakti, defence, the green and blue economy, and soft power. He announced AI skill training for ten million young people in a year, free online coaching for competitive exams, plans for seven or eight new semiconductor plants, a 100 GW nuclear energy goal by 2047 with five new reactors this decade, a national sports talent search for children aged five to fifteen, a modern civil-defence network, and a proposal for 33 per cent women’s reservation. Modi pointed out the increase in solar capacity from 2 GW to 160 GW and the Surya Ghar program reaching five million homes. These changes are clear and measurable. Financial inclusion reached even the most remote areas. Better sanitation improved people’s dignity. Tap water and solar power became common. Health coverage protected those most at risk. Startups and self-help groups created jobs. Infrastructure and defence production grew significantly. India’s digital systems became models for the world. Renewable energy grew fourfold, solar power increased 57-fold, and rooftop solar changed how households use energy, making energy security possible.

Over thirteen Independence Day speeches from the Red Fort, Modi used the event to launch new policies. Early speeches focused on basic needs, while later ones highlighted self-reliance, technology, and making the most of India’s young people. The announced initiatives have promoted financial inclusion. They have improved sanitation, expanded insurance, and increased access to electricity. Now, these efforts are helping the next generation prepare for a future shaped by artificial intelligence. India is no longer just trying to catch up.



The author is the Resident Editor of The Pioneer

Gaumutra in perspective: Traditional knowledge and modern science stand together



JB GUPTA

Few subjects in India’s traditional healthcare evoke as much discussion as Gaumutra. Revered in Ayurveda, questioned in public discourse, and increasingly examined by

modern science, it represents a unique intersection of traditional knowledge, biomedical research, socio-cultural debate and public policy. The challenge today is to approach the subject not through ideology, but through objective evidence.

The debate surrounding Gaumutra extends far beyond traditional medicine. It now encompasses scientific inquiry, public health, and political discourse. Cow-derived dairy products are globally accepted as a rich source of nutrition. Ayurveda, India’s traditional system of medicine, has used cow-derived formulations for centuries as medicines. However, other than cow milk, public opinion often oscillates between unquestioning reverence and outright dismissal of these cow-derived therapeutic products. Neither extreme does justice to the subject. An objective assessment requires examining Gaumutra within its Ayurvedic context, alongside modern scientific evidence and broader insights from other bio-derived therapeutics. Samhita, Sushruta Samhita and Ashtanga Hridaya, classify Gaumutra among the Ashta

Mutra, or eight medicinal animal urines. Ayurvedic pharmacology describes it as possessing *Katu* (pungent) and *Tikta* (bitter) tastes, *Ushna* (warming) *potency* and *Tikshna* (penetrating) properties.

Traditionally, Gaumutra has been prescribed to stimulate digestive fire (Deepana), improve metabolism (Pachana), support the management of skin disorders (Kushtha and Twak Roga), and address conditions such as *Medoroga*, *Shotha* and *Udara Roga*. It is also recognised as a Yogavahi, a catalytic medium believed to enhance the absorption and therapeutic efficacy of herbal, mineral and metallic preparations used in Ayurveda.

Equally important is the dosage form in which it is administered. Classical Ayurveda rarely recommends the consumption of raw, untreated cow urine. Instead, it emphasises Gaumutra Ark, a purified distillate obtained through controlled vaporisation and condensation, or its use in traditional formulations such as Panchagavya, which combines cow milk, curd, ghee, urine and dung in specific proportions. Processing and formulation have always remained integral to Ayurvedic therapeutics.

Scientific interest in Gaumutra has grown steadily over the past two decades. Laboratory analyses have identified a range of naturally occurring constituents, including urea, uric acid, allantoin, hippuric acid, phenolic acids such as gallic, caffeic, ferulic and salicylic acids, essential minerals including calcium, magnesium, potassium, sodium and phosphates, as well as enzymes. These findings have encouraged researchers to investi-



gate their possible biological significance.

One of the most significant developments is research on ‘Cow Urine Distillate (CUD)’, also known as Go-Ark, as a potential bioenhancer. Research undertaken by the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), in collaboration with the Central Institute of Medicinal and Aromatic Plants (CIMAP), resulted in two U.S. patents in 2002 and 2005 relating to the use of CUD for enhancing the effectiveness of certain antibiotics and anticancer drugs. Studies cited in the literature suggest that CUD may improve the absorption of antibiotics such as rifampicin and ampicillin, as well as anticancer drugs including paclitaxel, thereby enhancing their efficacy.

Published laboratory studies have reported antioxidant activity through free-radical scavenging, while other investigations have demonstrated antibacterial and antifungal effects against several microorganisms, such as *Escherichia coli*, *Staphylococcus aureus*, *Klebsiella* species, *Candida albicans*, etc., under controlled laboratory condi-

tions. These observations provide scientific leads for further investigation into the biological properties of Gaumutra and its distilled preparations.

Viewed in isolation, Gaumutra often appears exceptional. However, modern pharmacology has long relied on biologically derived materials for developing life-saving medicines.

Human urine has provided compounds such as urokinase and menotropins. Gila monster saliva led to the development of Exendin-4 for Type 2 diabetes. Hirudin from leech saliva, peptides from Jararaca viper venom, heparin, insulin and conjugated estrogens demonstrate the therapeutic potential of biological materials.

The distinguishing factor has never been the biological source itself, but the rigorous scientific process through which active molecules are isolated, characterised, standardised, tested for safety and evaluated through clinical trials.

The discussion gained renewed public attention in January 2025 when V Kamakoti, Director of IIT Madras, referred to the traditional medicinal uses of Gaumutra during a public address, citing its reported antibacterial, antifungal and digestive properties.

The remarks triggered immediate debate. Medical associations cautioned against promoting the consumption of unprocessed cow urine because of the potential risks of zoonotic infections and other health concerns. At the same time, supporters argued that traditional knowledge systems deserve scientific investigation rather than outright dismissal. The issue resurfaced after Prof. Kamakoti received the Padma Shri in 2026, with discussions once again extending beyond science into the

broader realm of public discourse.

The continuing debate over Gaumutra reflects differences in scientific interpretation, public perception, cultural identity and political narratives. Exaggerated claims without sufficient evidence can undermine scientific credibility, while blanket rejection of traditional formulations risks overlooking potentially valuable avenues of investigation.

Another important issue concerns methodology. Scientific scepticism often arises from advocacy of raw, unprocessed cow urine rather than standardised preparations. Concerns regarding microbial contamination and zoonotic infections reinforce the need to distinguish between raw biological material and purified formulations such as Gaumutra Ark.

Equally important is the evidence gap. While laboratory findings are encouraging, large-scale, well-designed human clinical trials remain limited. Bridging this gap requires rigorous chemical profiling, safety evaluation, pharmacological studies, standardised manufacturing and robust clinical trials.

The discussion on Gaumutra should neither be driven by unquestioning belief nor automatic dismissal. Traditional knowledge and modern science need not stand in opposition. Moving beyond political rhetoric and focusing on evidence-based investigation offers the most credible path forward. Gaumutra Ark should be evaluated through rigorous scientific standards to establish its safety, efficacy and clinical relevance.

The writer is an Ayush Distinguished Scientist at the Ministry of Ayush

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

Delhi HC grants week to Govt for response on same-sex plea



The Delhi High Court on Thursday questioned the Centre for its failure to respond, even after a year, to a petition seeking recognition of same-sex couples as medical representatives during medical treatment.

The court orally observed that when people are allowed to enter into a live-in relationship with same-sex partners, then the authorities have to make changes in the rules accordingly.

"The law recognises a live-in relationship between a man and a woman. Why will it not allow a live-in relationship between a man and a man?"

"Whenever a person chooses a path which is not a path taken by the majority, they will be targeted or looked down upon; or not looked down but will not be accepted. I have many cases where the families give them up and do not accept the relation," Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma said.

The court, which had issued notice to the Centre and National Medical Commission (NMC) in July 2025, asked why the authorities have not filed their replies yet.

"You need to tell me what your stand is. This fight is what for?" the court said. (PTI)

Narayan Rane offers to settle defamation case filed by Raut



BJP MP Narayan Rane on Thursday told a court here that he was willing to settle the defamation case filed against him by Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut.

Raut, who is also a Rajya Sabha member, had filed a criminal defamation complaint against the former Union minister for allegedly making "malicious and false" remarks against him at the Konkani Festival held in Bhandup in the metropolis on January 15, 2023.

During the hearing of the matter before the Mazgaon magistrate court, Rane's lawyer Satishmane Shinde "offered for the settlement of the complaint".

However, advocate Sarthak Shetty, appearing for Raut, said that they had not received any proposal yet.

A decision on settlement can be taken only after the proposal is received, he added.

Rane had allegedly said Raut's name did not exist in the voters' list and that he (Rane), when he was in the undivided Shiv Sena, had helped the latter get elected to the Rajya Sabha.

Taking cognisance of the complaint, the Mazgaon court had issued process (summons) to the BJP MP.

Rane challenged the summons before a special court dealing with cases against MPs and MLAs, saying no defamation case was made out against him.

The special court had upheld the summons, saying Rane made "vague and unsubstantiated" statements against Raut "indicating malice". (PTI)

Delhi HC asks trial court to defer evidence in Chinese visa case against Karti Chidambaram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday directed a trial court to defer recording of evidence in the alleged Chinese visa scam case in which Congress MP Karti Chidambaram is facing prosecution on charges of corruption and criminal conspiracy.

Justice Manoj Jain directed the trial court not to record statements of witnesses till October 8. "It would be appropriate that the trial court defers recording of evidence in the case till the next date of hearing (before the high court)," Justice Jain said.

The high court was informed that the matter is listed before the trial court this Friday.

The high court passed the order on separate pleas by the CBI, Karti Chidambaram and other accused challenging the framing of charges in the case.



While Karti Chidambaram and other accused have challenged the framing of corruption and conspiracy charges on the ground that no case was made out against them, CBI has sought framing of additional charges against the accused.

During the hearing, the CBI's counsel argued that the trial be permitted to go on and the probe agency be allowed to record statements of some of the former witnesses who are old and crucial to the



Shinde faction reaping fruits of defection: Sena (UBT) tells SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Shiv Sena (UBT) on Thursday told the Supreme Court that the Eknath Shinde-led faction continued to enjoy the "fruits of defection" and the Election Commission granted Shiv Sena's name and the symbol to them substantially based on the legislative majority test.

The submissions were made before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, which resumed hearing on the seventh day the challenge of the Uddhav Thackeray faction to the EC's decision recognising the Shinde-headed group as the "real Shiv Sena" and allotting it the party name and the 'bow and arrow' election symbol.

Senior advocate Devadatt Kamat, appearing for the Thackeray faction, said the Shinde group continue to reap the benefits of that defection because the symbols order of the poll panel stood on the basis of the legislative majority test.

"In this case, they have already enjoyed the fruits of defection because the matter could not be heard in time. We are not blaming anybody. But they continue to reap the benefits even today. The symbols order stands based on the legisla-



tive majority test," Kamat said. "Once disqualified, they lose their membership," Kamat said, adding that the alleged defectors had already benefited from the delay in deciding the disqualification petitions.

The bench questioned Kamat on the scope of the relief being sought. "Disqualified from what?" the bench asked.

Kamat responded that disqualification was a legal consequence flowing from the act of defection and that the court could declare the date from which the members incurred disqualification, even if consequential relief could no longer be effectively granted.

"It is a legal declaration that the member lost his membership from the date

on which the act of defection was committed," he said.

The senior advocate said that the top court, in the past, itself determined the disqualification in appropriate circumstances rather than remanding the matter to the Speaker.

He referred to the Supreme Court's judgement in a case and said that the court had previously held that the constitutional scheme under the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution could not be allowed to be undermined by inaction or failure on the part of the Speaker.

"In extraordinary circumstances, where the Speaker fails to decide, the Supreme Court can itself determine disqualification in the first instance," Kamat said. He said the circumstances in the

present case warranted a similar approach, particularly because the dispute over the party's identity and election symbol was directly linked to the legislative majority relied upon by the EC.

"The fruit of the alleged defection which they continue to enjoy today is the party symbol. That symbol rests upon their so-called legislative majority," he said.

"We are only urging Your Lordships to decide this issue — whether they have committed defection or not. If they did, one of the principal grounds on which the Election Commission awarded them the symbol disappears," he said.

He said that the speaker's order, which favoured the Shinde camp, was illegal and had a "definitive impact" on the symbol dispute. Kamat said that the EC was not justified in applying the "test of legislative majority" while the legality of the MLAs' status was still in question.

On Wednesday, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, also appearing for the Thackeray group, had argued that recognising the Shinde faction as the "real" Shiv Sena would amount to rewarding what he termed a "constitutional sin".

The Shinde group would resume its final arguments on September 2.

1978 industry definition won't apply to 2020 code: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court, by a majority of 6:3, on Thursday held that the labour-friendly expansive definition of the term "industry" in its 1978 verdict shall not be considered for the interpretation of the Industrial Relations Code of 2020.

A nine-judge Constitution bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant also, by a majority verdict, held that the reference seeking reconsideration of a 1978 judgement by a seven-judge bench on the

definition of "industry" was validly made.

On February 21, 1978, the seven-judge bench had delivered a verdict on the definition of the term "industry" while deciding the plea of Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board and expanded its definition, which brought millions of employees in hospitals, educational institutions, clubs and government welfare departments under the protection of the Industrial Disputes (ID) Act, 1947.

The CJ, who authored the majority verdict for himself



and Justices Satish Chandra Sharma, Alok Aradhe and Vipul M Pancholi, made clear that the "triple test",

evolved in the 1978 judgement, to ascertain what constitutes an "industry" will remain valid.

However, the "triple test" will be applied in labour-related pending cases lodged under the now-repealed 1947 ID Act.

Justices PS Narasimha and Joymalya Bagchi penned separate verdicts, broadly agreeing with the majority judgement of the CJ. Both the judges held that the reference seeking reconsideration of the 1978 verdict on the definition of the term "industry" was valid.

Don't let children face pressure over 3-language policy: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that children should not come under any kind of pressure, the Supreme Court on Thursday stressed the need to find a solution to issues arising out of the CBSE policy mandating the study of three languages by Class 9 students.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana observed there was nothing wrong in introducing the policy, but the only concern raised by the petitioners was about the manner in which it was being introduced.

"Some of these problems, you may revisit. There is no



doubt that sooner or later, it has to be introduced. There is nothing wrong with that. But how it is to be streamlined so that whatever impediments or blockades are coming up, you may find a solution to those," the bench told

Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati.

The bench said one of the aspects that was required to be considered was how to build adequate human resource infrastructure for the language options available.

"If you have chosen Class 6 as the starting point, you may consider giving a reprieve to Class 6 students of this year. You can introduce it from next year," it said.

"Another thing which needs to be looked into is where you draw the line. Whether it is Class 6, Class 4 or Class 3. You can take a call depending on the curriculum and where the choice between two and three languages is first introduced," the bench said.

It said one of the concerns was whether we consider English a native language or a foreign language.

"As the Union of India, you will also have to see that other than the CBSE, what is happening in other boards,"

the bench told Bhati, adding that it has to be ensured that the roll-out of the policy is appropriately undertaken.

Bhati said she would take instructions on the suggestions and get back to the court.

"We don't want the children to come under any pressure," the CJ said.

The top court was hearing a batch of pleas challenging the CBSE's policy mandating the study of three languages, including two native Indian languages, for Class 9 students from July 1.

At the outset, senior advocate Anand Grover, appearing for some of the petitioners, told the bench that the issue relates to three languages and that they were concerned with Class 6.

give its report on the issue within three months.

The bench was hearing a contempt petition filed by Justice VS Dave, President of the Association of Retired Judges of the Supreme Court and High Courts, raising the issue of security and other facilities for retired judges.

During the hearing, the CJ had questioned the adequacy of the financial assistance currently provided by some States for engaging security personnel and drivers.

that the Centre has not set up the panel so far, said that if it is not done, then the court itself will set up the committee.

Earlier, on July 20, the bench had asked the Centre to set up the panel within two weeks for a uniform national policy regarding post-retirement benefits like services of drivers, security and stay in government accommodations for former High Court judges while travelling.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the submissions of Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati that the Government be given some more time to set up the panel.

SC asks Govt to form panel in a week for ex-HC judges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday granted one more week to the Centre to set up a panel for a uniform national policy on post-retirement benefits such as services of drivers, security and stay in government accommodations for former High Court judges while travelling.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the submissions of Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati that the Government be given some more time to set up the panel.

"The Additional Solicitor General seeks one week to set up the committee," the bench said, adding that the matter will now be listed after 10 days.

During the brief hearing, the bench, after being told



that the Centre has not set up the panel so far, said that if it is not done, then the court itself will set up the committee.

Earlier, on July 20, the bench had asked the Centre to set up the panel within two weeks for a uniform national policy regarding post-retirement benefits like services of drivers, security and stay in government accommodations for former High Court judges while travelling for former High Court judges.

It had also directed that the panel would have to

give its report on the issue within three months.

The bench was hearing a contempt petition filed by Justice VS Dave, President of the Association of Retired Judges of the Supreme Court and High Courts, raising the issue of security and other facilities for retired judges.

During the hearing, the CJ had questioned the adequacy of the financial assistance currently provided by some States for engaging security personnel and drivers.

Restricting social media for children Govt's domain, says Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday said banning or regulating the use of social media by children fell in the realm of the Centre's policy-making, and asked the authorities to decide on this aspect. A bench of Justices V Kameswar Rao and Manmeet PS Arora refused to entertain a public interest litigation (PIL) seeking to restrict the use of social media by children and asked the central Government to consider it as a representation.

The bench, however, refused to set a timeline for the authorities to complete the exercise. "Your views would be taken into consideration by the respondents. The stakeholders have to be consulted. Their views have to be taken, and then it is in the realm of a policy. It is not for a court to give a direction that you should ban this, or that you should ban that. Let them look into it and then pass an order," the bench told the petitioner's lawyer.

The petitioner sought a direction to the Centre to consider enacting a law or guidelines to "restrict" the use of social media by children under the age of 13 years.

It also prayed for a framework to "regulate" social



media content for children aged 13-16 years.

Central Government Counsel Nidhi Raman said the issue of restricting or regulating the use of social media was a policy issue which has to be considered by the Centre as it may require enactment of a new law.

Such a policy will have wider ramifications, and would require stakeholder consultation, she added.

The Centre's counsel submitted that the petitioner's plea can be considered as a representation by the authorities and an appropriate order can be passed.

On being asked by the court if any action was taken after an earlier Supreme Court order on the issue, the lawyer said that the Digital Personal Data Protection Act has been enacted, which also safeguards children's privacy online.

The majority verdict also made clear that it will not apply to the 2020 Code and any fresh case under the new law will be adjudicated based on its facts and the context. Justice Nagarathna held that the 1978 verdict was correct and there was no need to refer it for reconsideration.

All the nine judges were in agreement on the issue that since the 1947 Act has now been repealed and a new law has come into being, the matter has become an academic exercise.

The detailed judgments are awaited.

Talk to children to build bond, SC tells parents



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday told parents that instead of sending their children to too many classes like music and taekwondo, they should take out some time and talk to them.

While hearing a child custody case, a bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and R Mahadevan questioned the parents for enrolling their kids in multiple after-school activities to give them a competitive edge.

"The parents should treat them, give them good etiquette, manners — boys especially. How they should treat girls and women, they should teach them. Parents should teach them instead of sending them to extra classes. That is how the bond will develop between the parents and the children," Justice Nagarathna observed.

On the top court's observation, an advocate appearing for one of the parties said that such classes help the child in all-around development for a highly competitive world.

Justice Nagarathna then said, "So many classes are also not good for children. Parents should just sit with them and talk to them."

"They will become better children; there will be better interaction. Instead of sending them to art class, music class, taekwondo, something else. Instead of that, you take a class with your children."

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

DPIIT inks MoU with PhonePe, Shell India to support startups

PhonePe

The Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) on Thursday said it has inked pacts with PhonePe and Shell India to support startups.

The partnerships are aimed at enhancing access to technology, digital infrastructure, mentorship, market opportunities, and industry networks, it said.

Under its collaboration with DPIIT, PhonePe will provide DPIIT-recognised startups with a range of benefits, including transaction credits through its payment gateway, access to the Indus AppStore, dedicated onboarding and support services, and opportunities for enhanced brand visibility.

The MoU with Shell India will focus on supporting startups operating in the energy and climate-tech sectors.

Through this partnership, Shell India will provide mentorship, strategic guidance, investor and incubator connect, and opportunities to participate in the Shell E4 Smart Energy Track.

The initiative is expected to help startups access growth opportunities, scale innovative solutions and contribute to India's clean energy transition, it said. (PTI)

India-EU trade pact clears legal scrubbing: Official

India and the 27-nation European Union (EU) have completed the legal scrubbing of the trade pact text and it will be signed this year on a mutually agreed date, an official said on Thursday.

On January 27, India and the European Union announced the conclusion of negotiations for the free trade agreement, described as the "mother of all deals", under which 93 per cent of Indian shipments will enjoy duty-free access to the 27-nation bloc, while imports of luxury cars and wines from the EU will become less expensive.

"The scrubbing is over," the official said.

Taken together, India and the EU account for 25 per cent of the global GDP and one-third (about \$11 trillion) of international trade (about \$33 trillion). (PTI)

SEBI eases FPI onboarding by allowing digitally signed PoA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Capital markets regulator SEBI on Thursday eased the onboarding process for foreign portfolio investors by allowing them to submit a digitally signed power of attorney to their custodians.

Under the revised rule, an FPI can give a Power of Attorney (PoA) to its custodian specifying its address and execute the document by using a digital signature in accordance with the provi-

sions of the Information Technology Act, 2000, SEBI said. A Power of Attorney is a document through which a foreign portfolio investor (FPI) authorises its custodian to act on its behalf.

For an FPI, a custodian is a financial institution that

imports even as policy ambition accelerates, the research, titled 'Chasing Self-Sufficiency: Cost of Building an Indigenous Battery Supply Chain in India', said.

Despite more than 226 GWh of cell manufacturing capacity announced for construction through 2035, execution delays, financial viability challenges and deep technology dependence on Chinese and Korean licensors mean India remains 10 to 15 years from a globally competitive, self-sufficient cell industry.

India has just 2 GWh of commissioned cell manufacturing capacity as of

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | AUGUST 21, 2026

Local currencies cut cross-border trade costs: RBI deputy governor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Local currencies will play an ever-increasing role in cross-border trade and payments as they lower transaction costs, reduce currency mismatches, and improve settlement efficiency, RBI Deputy Governor Rohit Jain has said.

Speaking at the Annual Day of the Foreign Exchange Dealers' Association of India (FEDAI) last week on 'India's Foreign Exchange Markets: Getting ready for the next Decade', Jain said that by their very nature, markets are continuously evolving and parameters of their readiness are being regularly renewed according to the needs of the time.

"Our market would be ready for the next decade if it can help facilitate India's ever-

increasing engagement with other countries, absorb shocks in a non-disruptive manner, serve the smallest user as efficiently as the biggest, and embrace new technology without vitiating the trust it has earned," he said.

The deputy governor said India's foreign exchange reserves have risen from about \$38 billion in 2000 to

\$691 billion in 2026. The average daily turnover in the domestic forex market, spot and derivatives combined, has doubled from \$41 billion in FY22 to about \$80 billion at present.

Talking about drivers that will shape India's forex markets in the coming decade, Jain said local currencies will play an ever-

increasing role in cross-border trade and payments.

The Special Rupee Vostro Account (SRVA) framework for invoicing, payment and settlement of international trade in rupees has been implemented keeping in view the evolving dynamics of our international trade.

Its success, he said, will depend on commercial viability, emphasis on trade settlement in local currencies, offering market-determined rates, and strengthening confidence in the settlement ecosystem.

"The settlement of cross-border transactions in local currencies results in lower transaction costs, fewer currency mismatches, better settlement efficiency, and the ability to trade where correspondent banking is costly or constrained," the deputy governor said.

Rupee settles on flat note, higher by 3 paise at 95.70

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The rupee pared initial gains and settled for the day with gains of just 3 paise at 95.70 against the US dollar on Thursday, as the support from the weaker dollar index was negated by elevated crude oil prices.

Forex traders said while a weaker US dollar eases some depreciation pressure on the domestic currency, crude oil hovering above \$90 would continue to keep pressure on India's import bill. The dollar index fell to its lowest level since late May after the US Treasury announced that it would double its buyback operations for longer-dated Treasury bonds, pushing US long-term yields lower and reducing the dollar's yield advantage.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.57 against the greenback and traded in a range of 95.56-95.72 during the session. It even-

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)	Change
13	95.45	-0.12
14	95.61	-0.19
17	95.42	+0.03
18	95.74	-0.13
19	95.73	+0.01
20	95.70*	+0.03

*Provisional
August 2026
(Inverted scale) KBK Infographics

tually settled at 95.70 (provisional), higher by 3 paise from its previous close. On Wednesday, the rupee stayed almost flat, ending just 1 paise higher at 95.73 against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 98.61, lower by 0.22 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 2.22 per cent at \$93.65 per barrel in futures trade. According to Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset Sharekhan, the rupee opened higher on weak dollar and positive domestic markets. However, rupee pared initial gains on rising crude oil prices.

We expect the rupee to trade with a slight negative bias on renewed geopolitical tensions between the US and Iran after US President Donald Trump announced crushing economic sanctions against Iran.

Kia begins Sorento production ahead of India launch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Kia India has commenced production of the Sorento premium three-row SUV at its Anantapur manufacturing facility, ahead of the model's scheduled India launch on September 4.

The company has also released the first official images of the Sorento, which will expand Kia's presence in India's premium SUV segment. The model is being manufactured locally and is positioned as the brand's flagship SUV for the Indian market.

The Sorento will be Kia India's first hybrid SUV, with

an all-wheel-drive system. It will also be offered with a diesel powertrain, giving buyers a choice between electrified and conventional propulsion. The company said the move forms part of its broader multi-powertrain strategy for India.

A key technology feature of the India-bound Sorento will be Kia's AI Assistant, powered by live generative artificial intelligence. According to the company, the India-specification Sorento will be the first model globally to introduce the technology across Kia's

product portfolio. It will also mark the first deployment of live generative AI in the Indian automotive industry, Kia said.

Unlike conventional voice assistants that respond to a limited set of commands, the system is designed to

support more conversational interactions and provide access to real-time information. Kia expects the feature to enhance the vehicle's technology and premium positioning.

The first locally produced Sorento rolled off the assembly line at Anantapur on Thursday. Kia began manufacturing vehicles at the Andhra Pradesh plant in 2019. The facility has an installed annual production capacity of 400,000 units and serves both domestic and export markets.

"With the first locally produced Sorento rolling off the production line at our Anantapur facility today, we

are taking an important step in bringing this globally acclaimed premium flagship SUV to Indian customers," said Gwanggu Lee, managing director and CEO, Kia India.

Pre-bookings for the Sorento are currently open through Kia India dealerships and the company's official website. Pricing and detailed specifications are expected to be announced at the launch.

Kia India has dispatched nearly 1.9 million vehicles from its Anantapur plant, including more than 1.5 million units sold domestically and over 367,000 exported, according to company data. It operates 892 touchpoints across 407 Indian cities.

Sensex jumps 628 points, Nifty snaps 7-day losing streak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices bounced back on Thursday, with the Sensex climbing 628 points and the Nifty snapping its seven-day losing streak as easing global bond yields fueled a stock rally worldwide.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 628.04 points, or 0.82 per cent, to settle at 77,537.72 after four days of decline. During the day, it surged 701.43 points, or 0.91 per cent, to 77,611.11.

Snapping its seven-day falling streak, the 50-share

Open:	24,225.45
High:	24,265.15
Low:	24,184.55
Close:	24,231.85
Previous close:	24,078.30

Open:	77,468.45
High:	77,611.11
Low:	77,371.00
Close:	77,537.72
Previous close:	76,909.68

KBK Infographics

NSE Nifty rose by 153.55 points, or 0.64 per cent, to close at 24,231.85.

"Markets found much-needed relief after the US Treasury stepped in to

contain the surge in global bond yields, triggering a strong broad-based rebound and ending the domestic market's week-long losing streak. The intervention has dragged down the dollar, which, along with a firmer rupee and easing yield pressures, boosted attractiveness to EMs," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

The recovery was widespread across sectors, driven primarily by strength in IT and financial stocks, as a cooling yield environment supports spending, he said.

Govt official asks industry to utilise FTAs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Thursday nudged the industry to utilise Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), focus on value addition, build resilient supply chains, and actively diversify export markets to boost manufacturing and strengthen the country's position in global trade.

All trade agreements India has signed "are a door, but doors, however magnificently crafted, do not open themselves. It is the industry that must walk through them," said Additional Secretary in the Department of Commerce Yashvir Singh.

He said the industry should use FTAs to expand market access, attract investment and technology, diversify supply chains, and build manufacturing ecosystems that can withstand global shocks.

The ambition is not merely to participate in global manufacturing but to make India a reliable, competitive, and trusted partner in global value chains, he said at a manufacturing conclave.

India's battery storage self-reliance a decade away: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

It would take another 10 years for India to achieve self-sufficiency in battery storage as there is a huge gap between the demand and current capability to manufacture essential battery cell components, according to Wood Mackenzie.

India's domestic battery manufacturing currently accounts for less than 1 per cent (2 GWh) of its approximately 260 GWh demand pipeline from competitive tenders in 2026, the research said.

The gap leaves the country structurally dependent on

imports even as policy ambition accelerates, the research, titled 'Chasing Self-Sufficiency: Cost of Building an Indigenous Battery Supply Chain in India', said.

Despite more than 226 GWh of cell manufacturing capacity announced for construction through 2035, execution delays, financial viability challenges and deep technology dependence on Chinese and Korean licensors mean India remains 10 to 15 years from a globally competitive, self-sufficient cell industry.

India has just 2 GWh of commissioned cell manufacturing capacity as of

2026, against China's cumulative capacity of 2,695 GWh, the report said, noting China controls

between 85 per cent and 98 per cent of global capacity across every major supply chain component, from

cathode to anode, separator and electrolyte.

Bridging that gap will require India to fundamentally restructure its manufacturing ecosystem, it said.

"India's battery storage ambitions are credible, but the gap between policy intent and operational capacity is wide," said Ankita Chauhan, director, Wood Mackenzie.

The near-term opportunity lies in downstream components such as containers and battery packs, where localisation is both technically feasible and commercially attractive, she said.

Chauhan said the harder work of building a self-suf-

ficient cell industry will take a decade or more and requires sustained, targeted investment that goes well beyond the incentive schemes currently in place.

According to Wood Mackenzie, locally manufactured cells are expected to cost 25-40 per cent more than imported ones, driven by limited scale, higher financing costs and an underdeveloped supplier ecosystem.

Yet India's underlying cost position is globally competitive by offering a 154 per cent cost advantage over Japan and a 9 per cent advantage over South Korea, placing it second

only to China among major manufacturing destinations.

Cell manufacturing is expected to develop progressively with imported inputs over the next two to five years, while full refining capabilities will take more than ten years to establish.

India is expected to prioritise the localisation of downstream components, including containers, energy management systems, SCADA, and battery packs, over the next two to three years, supported by a 20 per cent domestic content requirement now applied to grid-scale BESS projects under new tenders.

Singapore PM holds bilateral talks with Indian ministers

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

Prime Minister Lawrence Wong on Thursday met visiting Indian ministers ahead of the fourth India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR) and discussed ways to build on the progress made in bilateral ties, particularly in advanced manufacturing, digitalisation, sustainability and connectivity.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, and Minister of State for Electronics and IT Jitin Prasada are in the city-state to participate in the ministerial-level meeting. In a series of social media posts, Wong said it was a pleasure to



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and Minister of State Jitin Prasada, pose for a group photograph alongside Singaporean Deputy Prime Minister Gan Kim Yong and other senior dignitaries during the India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR), in Singapore.

catch up with Sitharaman, Jaishankar, Goyal and Prasada ahead of the ISMR, which began on Thursday.

The leaders discussed how Singapore and India can “build on the good progress made through ISMR” and take the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership further, especially in advanced manufacturing, digitalisation, sustainability and connectivity. Wong said the discussions also covered regional and global developments.

“Singapore and India share a longstanding and increasingly close partnership. I wish the ministers a productive visit and fruitful discussions at the ISMR,” he said. According to a Singapore Government statement, the ISMR is an

important ministerial-level platform for the two countries to drive cooperation in new and emerging areas.

The fourth ISMR will review the progress from the third ISMR, held in New Delhi in August 2025, and identify new opportunities to advance the implementation of the Singapore India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Roadmap, the ministries of Foreign Affairs and Trade and Industry said in a joint statement.

Sitharaman is leading the Indian delegation, while Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Trade and Industry (Trade) Gan Kim Yong is heading the Singapore delegation at the fourth roundtable. (PTI)

Telangana CM in London at start of 10-day UK, US tour



ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy has kicked off a 10-day tour of the UK and US after arriving in London on Thursday. In the UK, Reddy is scheduled to visit the Blavatnik School of Government at the University of Oxford and the Emirates Stadium for an EPL Football presentation, according to the State Government.

Interactions and events are also planned with the University of Cambridge, University of London and London Business School (LBS) during the first leg of his two-nation tour.

The Telagana CM will then head to the US next week, where he is set to visit the

campuses of Harvard University and Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT).

He is also scheduled to interact with a team from Virginia Tech University in Boston on August 25.

Besides some official discussions, a meet-and-greet diaspora event organised by the US chapter of the Indian Overseas Congress (IOC) in New York is also on the agenda. Earlier, Congress MP Mallu Ravi and the state Government's advisor on protocol affairs, Harkara Venugopal, saw him off at the New Delhi airport in the early hours of Thursday.

Reddy was in New Delhi to attend the Congress Working Committee (CWC) meeting on Wednesday. (PTI)

Russian missile, drone strikes kill 16 in Ukraine

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Russia pounded the Ukrainian Capital Kyiv and the surrounding region with scores of missiles and drones in a nighttime aerial attack that lasted for hours and killed at least 16 people, officials said on Thursday.

Moscow's forces have in recent months intensified their ballistic missile attacks on Kyiv, exploiting Ukraine's chronic shortage of US-made Patriot air defence interceptors, the sole weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down ballistic missiles.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has pleaded for countries to send more Patriot interceptors, but international stockpiles are low amid the Iran war and Ukraine's more than

four-year fight against Russia's all-out invasion.

Russia's overnight barrage also included cruise missiles and fast-flying jet-powered drones that put further strain on air defences, the Ukrainian air force said.

Explosions boomed across the city in the dark. Kyiv was the primary target, but hits were recorded at 28 locations across the country, according to the air force.

Emergency services said 15 people were killed in the capital, with another fatality in the wider Kyiv region. About 40 people were wounded, Zelenskyy said, as air raid warnings remained in place until after dawn.

“It was a massive attack,” Zelenskyy said on social media, adding that Russia “had been preparing (it) for



People taking shelter in a metro station in Kyiv, Ukraine

AP

a long time, combining different types of ballistic missiles, cruise missiles and drones, aiming to cause as much damage as possible to civilian infrastructure.”

But the Russian Defence

Ministry said the attack struck a Kyiv industrial site manufacturing components for Ukraine's Flamingo cruise missiles.

Sites involved in the production and storage of

drones, an ammunition depot and a logistics centre were also hit, it said.

Russia and Ukraine have battered each other with drones and missiles as their armies struggle to gain the upper hand on the 1,250-kilometre front line, where huge numbers of drones are pinning down troops.

Ukraine has attempted to shift the war onto Russian soil through long-range drone strikes on oil facilities and other infrastructure.

The Russian Defence Ministry said Thursday morning that air defences shot down 726 Ukrainian drones overnight over a number of Russian regions, annexed Crimea and the Black and Azov seas, in one of Ukraine's biggest aerial attacks of the war.

North Korea fires suspected missile toward sea, Japan claims



ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Seoul

North Korea launched a suspected ballistic missile toward the sea on Thursday, Japan said, a day after North Korea shrugged off a US decision to scale back military drills with South Korea in an apparent bid to resume diplomacy. The Japanese prime minister's office said it detected the suspected launch but gave no further details.

South Korean media, citing the military, reported that North Korea fired an unidentified projectile off the North's east coast.

On Wednesday, the South Korean and US militaries said they were scaling back their 11-day Ulchi Freedom Shield exercises. US President Donald Trump earlier ordered the Pentagon to “substantially reduce” the exercises, just before they began on Monday. Trump cited what he said was a good relationship with Kim and South Korea's refusal to support him over the war in Iran.

Rescuers recover more bodies after mine collapse in Central African Republic

JEAN FERNAND KOENA

■ Bangui

Hopes of finding survivors of a collapsed gold mine in Central African Republic were fading Thursday, two days after the disaster killed more than 100 people and left others buried under debris.

Rescuers continued recovering bodies from the artisanal mining site in Zamboye, near the border with Cameroon, but local workers said the response lacked the equipment and expertise needed for a disaster of such scale.

“The rescue effort is being organised, but it is not up to the task,” said Jeremie Ngbiri, a miner at the site who lost his brother and a friend in the collapse. Ngbiri said he saw some victims suffocate as people tried to rescue them.

The local Red Cross was helping with the search but



could not say how many people remained buried, volunteer Gervais Ganagoro said. “We continue to find bodies,” he said, adding that more than 10 were recovered

Thursday morning alone. “Every hour, bodies are being discovered, increasing the number of victims.”

The mine collapsed

Tuesday after a landslide. Local officials and the Red Cross said Wednesday that more than 100 people had died and warned the toll was likely to rise. Mines Minister

Rufin Benam Beltoungou expressed condolences to victims' families and warned miners about the dangers of unsafe mining practices, according to a statement posted by the ministry.

Some of the victims were from neighbouring Cameroon. Cameroon's Mines Ministry said both Cameroonian and Central African miners were believed to be among the dead and deployed a team to assess the situation along the border. The state-run Cameroon Tribune reported at least four Cameroonians were killed.

Artisanal mine collapses are common in Central African Republic, where thousands of people work in small-scale mining, often with little protection. Pits are frequently dug by hand and can reach several metres deep. (AP)

Collision with helicopter kills US pilot: Authorities



ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Washington

An airplane pilot died on Wednesday after a violent collision with a Pennsylvania State Police helicopter near a runway at a small airport, but both state troopers aboard the helicopter survived, authorities said.

The plane was coming down on the runway and veered into the helicopter that was near the ground, Lieutenant Colonel George Bivens, the State's acting police commissioner, said during a news conference.

The FAA and NTSB called it a mid-air collision but state police didn't clarify if the plane was off the ground. “When I say it was a very violent crash, that plane was cut into a lot of pieces,” he

said, explaining that part of the investigation will be making sure the pilot was the only person on board. He said the helicopter lost its blades and tail boom and crashed onto its side. The crash at the small airport in Carlisle, about 170 kilometers northwest of Philadelphia, involved the Bell 407 helicopter and the Cessna 150, according to the Federal Aviation Administration. The Cessna is a two-seat aircraft that is typically used as a trainer aircraft, according to Bivens.

Both of the pilots in the helicopter were trapped until one pushed out a window and helped the other out through it, said Bivens. The pilots, who are from the police's elite aviation unit and had been performing a training exercise, are stable.

PUBLIC NOTICE

CHANDEL AND DUTT OVERSEAS RECRUITMENT AGENCY LLP

RA Registration No.: B-3148/DEL/PART/100/5/11152/2025

This is to inform the general public, clients, business associates, and all concerned parties that CHANDEL AND DUTT OVERSEAS RECRUITMENT AGENCY LLP, having its registered office at C-156, Street No. 2, Block C, Fifth Floor, Chhatrapur Enclave Phase 2, Sanjay Colony, Bhati Mines, South Delhi - 110074, has decided to permanently close its overseas recruitment operations with effect from 14 August 2026. The decision has been taken due to the non-availability of sufficient recruitment demands and business opportunities.

Therefore, all recruitment-related activities under the above-mentioned Registration Certificate shall stand discontinued from 14 August 2026.

Authorized Signatory
Sushil Kumar Chandel
partner

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that the Minutes Book File & TDS File of VV Silver Palace Private Limited (CIN-U51909DL2005PTC133287, PAN- AABCE4427B) have been lost during transportation of the Company's records from the office of Statutory Auditor of the Company located at Rani Bagh, Delhi - 110034 to the Registered office of the Company on 18th August 2026. Any person finding or having information regarding the said records is requested to contact the Company at the details given below. An appropriate reward shall be offered to such person for their recovery. VV Silver Palace Private Limited regd. office: 3229-3232 Gali No.29,Plot no.57,Beadon Pura Karol Bagh New Delhi-110005 Contact:9811012463

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, VINOD KUMAR S/O SH. FAKIR CHAND R/O PLOT NO. 16/16 A, KH.NO. 15/10, FLAT NO. 5, UPPER GROUND FLOOR, SURAJ VIHAR, N.S.I.T. DWARKA, NEW DELHI-110078, hereby declare that I have severed all ties with my son VIPIN KASHYAP and his wife INDU, due to their mistreatment. I have disowned and debarred them from my movable and immovable properties. They shall be solely responsible for their acts and liabilities in the future.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Saurabh Jain, son of Sh. R.K. Jain alias Rajinder Kumar Jain, Registrant/ Allottee/ Mutatee under Application No. 33738 of Rohini Residential Scheme, 1981, had submitted FDR No. 13583, dated 18.04.1981, amounting to Rs. 5000/-. It is hereby informed that the aforesaid original FDR has been lost/misplaced. In this regard:- 1. NCR/FIR/Lost Report No. 532/04 dated 04.07.2004 has been lodged at Police Station Shalimar Bagh. 2. An Indemnity Bond has also been executed regarding the aforesaid FDR. If anybody has any objection/claim regarding the aforesaid FDR or finds the same, he/she may contact the undersigned within 15 days from publication of this notice. Address: 195, Block BK-1, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi-110088 Mobile No.: 9899191815

BSES

BSES Yamuna Power Limited

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER (ROADS). PUBLIC WORKS ROADS DEPARTMENT. ASSAM. GUWAHATI-03

No. CE/DEV/TB/72/2026-27/01

PRESS NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Chief Engineer (Roads), PWRD, Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3 invites Bids on behalf of Governor of Assam through Engineering, Procurement and construction (EPC) Mode-1, for 01 (One) no. of package for, "RE-CONSTRUCTION AND STRENGTHENING OF ROAD FROM CAPITAL POINT TO RANGIRKHARI, SILCHAR IN CACHAR DISTRICT OF ASSAM UNDER SOPD-G FOR THE YEAR 2026-27" amounting to Rs. 550.01 Lakh, (approx.) including 18% GST etc. from approved & eligible Firm/Contractors registered with PWRD, Assam and having experience in similar nature of work.

Details may be seen from 20.08.2026 at website www.assamtenders.gov.in. Amendment /Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWRD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in.

Note:-

- Schemes are not yet sanctioned by the competent authority. In the event of non - sanction of the schemes, the bids may be cancelled and no claim what so ever on this account shall be entertained from the bidders.
- The Bid Price may vary at the time of detail tendering for which no claim will be admissible.
- All terms & condition will be as per Bidding Documents.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer (Roads), PWRD,
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/117/21-Aug-26



SUNIL HEALTHCARE LIMITED
Regd. Office: 38E/252-A, Vijay Tower, Shahpurjat, New Delhi-110049
CIN-L24302DL1973PLC189662
Email:-info@sunilhealthcare.com/ Website: www.sunilhealthcare.com,
Tel:-+91-11-4943555/00, Fax: +91-11-43850087

NOTICE
(KIND ATTENTION: EQUITY SHAREHOLDERS OF SUNIL HEALTHCARE LTD.)
In order to send Annual reports, Notices and other communications to the shareholders in electronic mode for ensuing 52 nd Annual General Meeting which will be held through Video conferencing/other Audio Visual Mode, we request the Shareholders of Sunil Healthcare Limited, who have not yet registered their email address or bank account details, to register the same in respect of shares held in electronic form with the Depository through their Depository Participant(s) and in respect of shares held in physical form, a request letter in writing duly signed by the shareholder, requesting to the Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent, M/s Alankit Assignment Limited at "4E/2, Alankit House, Jhandewalan Extension, New Delhi 110055", Contact no. 91-11-42541234 email id: jalitap@alankit.com, rta@alankit.com, or to the Company Secretary of the Company at cs@sunilhealthcare.com; by quoting the Folio no. and self-attested copy of PAN Card.
Pursuant to General Circular Nos. 14/2020 dated 8 th April, 2020, 17/2020 dated 13 th April, 2020, and 22/2020 dated 15 th June, 2020, read with latest General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 and such other circulars issued from time to time in this regard (collectively referred to as the "MCA Circulars") and Latest Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/CFD-PoD- 2/P/CIR/2024/133 dated October 03, 2024 and other applicable circular issued in this regard by the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI Circulars"), the Company has enabled a process for limited purpose for receiving the Annual Report and Notice of the 52 nd Annual General Meeting (including remote e-voting/e-voting instructions) electronically and the member may temporarily update their email id by dropping a email alongwith signed request letter to our E-voting and Video conferencing Agency, MURF Intime India Pvt. Ltd. (formerly Link Intime India Pvt. Ltd.) at investorhelpdesk@in.mrms.murf.com or to the Company at cs@sunilhealthcare.com.

For Sunil Healthcare Limited
Sd/-
Satyendu Pattnaik
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer
M. No. F7736

Place: New Delhi
Date: 21.08.2026

PROSPECT

Congress marks Rajiv Gandhi's birth anniversary with hospital visits, aid to slum children



Congress workers led by former MLA Sushila Jaikishan and Kirari District President Varun Dhaka marked former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi's birth anniversary on Thursday. The leaders distributed fruits to patients at Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital, Baba Saheb Ambedkar Hospital, Bhagwan Mahavir Hospital and Maharishi Valmiki Hospital. Sports equipment and clothing were also distributed to underprivileged children in slum areas to promote sportsmanship. Workers raised slogans praising Rajiv Gandhi during the event. Dhaka described Rajiv Gandhi as a pioneer of India's communications revolution and the architect of Panchayati Raj, noting he became the country's youngest prime minister. Dhaka said the Congress has consistently supported the poor, Dalits, women, youth, labourers and farmers, citing Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi and Sanjay Gandhi as examples of this commitment. Among those participating in the constituency-wide distribution drive were Youth Congress SC Department Vice President Rahul Dhaka, District President Zahir Mansoori, and Block President Chandan Singh, along with several other party workers including Deepak Chunnilal, Pramod Panchal and Vijay Prakash Khandelwal. (PNS)

e-Lottery conducted for 350 residential plots under Madhuban-Bapudham Scheme

The Ghaziabad Development Authority (GDA) on Thursday successfully conducted the e-lottery process for 350 residential plots under the Madhuban-Bapudham Residential Scheme. This marked a significant step towards helping families make their dream of owning a home come true. The e-lottery was conducted over two days. On August 19, allotments were made for 109 plots under Types A, B, C and D. The next day, August 20, the e-lottery for 241 plots under Types E, F, G and H was conducted. The plots, ranging from 40 square metres to 200 square metres, were allotted through a transparent electronic process. The initiative was carried out under the guidance of the Government of Uttar Pradesh and aims to provide residential opportunities to members of the general public. The successful completion of the process brought relief and happiness to applicants who had been awaiting the outcome of the allotment. The e-lottery also reflects the authority's efforts to ensure transparency and fairness in the allocation of residential plots. For many successful applicants, the allotment marks the beginning of a new journey toward constructing a home and securing a stable future for their families. With the completion of the two-day e-lottery process, 350 families have taken an important step closer to turning their long-awaited aspiration of owning a home into reality. The visible joy among successful applicants underscored the significance of the initiative. (PNS)



Govt imposes stock limit for bulk sugar consumers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Sugar prices have turned bitter as they are rising rapidly across the country, driven by speculation over record-low stocks and the approaching festive season. This prompted the Government to impose a stock limit on sugar for bulk consumers, including confectionery makers, soft drink manufacturers, food processing industries, sweetmeat sellers and other institutional buyers.

Retail prices have risen by approximately 20 per cent since August 7 across major cities. The retail price of sugar has increased from ₹52 to around ₹62 over the past 12 days, representing a rise of 19-21 per cent. The all-India average ex-mill price rose to



₹5,400-5,500 a quintal on Tuesday, up from ₹3,900 a year earlier.

Union Food Minister Pralhad Joshi, in social media, announced that bulk consumers using more than 10 tonnes of sugar a month will not be allowed to hold stock beyond what they would consume in 15 days. The food ministry has notified the Sugar (Stockholding Limit of Bulk Consumers) Order, 2026,

which covers confectioners, soft drink manufacturers, food processing units, sweetmeat sellers and other institutional buyers.

The order will come into force from September 1 and remain in effect till November 30. This follows an earlier order, effective August 1 to November 30, capping stock with sugar dealers at 4,000 quintals for 30 days.

Sujalam Bharat ID will be the new age common identifier of rural water-supply system

Sujalam Bharat seeks to organise this information around common digital identifiers, standardised metadata and interoperable registries so that it can be used throughout the lifecycle of the water-supply system. In an interview, Kamal Kishore Soan, Additional Secretary & Mission Director, National Jal Jeevan Mission (NJJM) Drinking Water and Sanitation (DDWS), Ministry of Jal Shakti, said larger vision is to support the transition towards utility-based, data-driven rural water governance, with technology assisting public authorities while human oversight and institutional accountability remain central.

Q. DDWS has recently released the Policy on Data Sharing, Interoperability and Stakeholder Access under Sujalam Bharat Digital Public Infrastructure. What is the purpose and vision behind it?

A. Jal Jeevan Mission has enabled creation and augmentation of rural piped water-supply infrastructure at an unprecedented scale. As this infrastructure is mapped, commissioned and brought into service, large volumes of information are also being generated on schemes, water sources, assets, service areas,



Kamal Kishore Soan

water quality, functionality and operation and maintenance.

Sujalam Bharat seeks to organise this information around common digital identifiers, standardised metadata and interoperable registries so that it can be used throughout the lifecycle of the water-supply system.

The larger vision is to support the transition towards utility-based, data-driven rural water governance, with technology assisting public authorities while human oversight and institutional accountability remain central.

Q. Why is a common digital framework particularly important at this stage of Jal Jeevan Mission?

A. This is an appropriate stage to establish the digital identity of infrastructure while schemes, sources and

assets are being created, mapped and institutionalised.

If common identifiers are established now, future information relating to maintenance, functionality, water quality, expenditure, source sustainability and service delivery can continue to be linked with the same infrastructure throughout its operational life.

Q. What are the key identifiers under Sujalam Bharat?

A. The Sujalam Bharat ID is the common identifier of a rural water-supply system, linking its infrastructure from the source through treatment, transmission, storage and distribution to its service area or service areas.

A Sujalam Bharat ID may be linked with multiple Sujal Gaon IDs, which represent the respective service areas. This creates a common index around which information generated through different systems can be organised.

Q. Is Sujalam Bharat a centralised data system? What role do States have?

A. No. Sujalam Bharat is designed as a federated Digital Public Infrastructure.

States and Union Territories will continue to maintain and govern datasets and digital services under their jurisdiction. State-controlled data

will remain subject to the approval and governance of the competent State authority. At the same time, common identifiers, metadata standards and interoperability protocols will allow State and national systems to communicate with each other.

The objective is therefore not centralisation of State data, but interoperability with distributed ownership and accountability.

Q. How will this improve operation and maintenance?

A. Once information on an asset, its location, functionality, maintenance history, breakdowns, water quality and service level is linked through common identifiers, States and local institutions can undertake more systematic and preventive O&M.

The framework can support maintenance workflows, dashboards, mobile applications, asset-health monitoring and predictive systems so that data leads to timely action.

Q. How does Sujalam Bharat create a foundation for Artificial Intelligence?

A. AI is useful only when the underlying data is reliable, structured and traceable.

Sujalam Bharat seeks to create that foundation

SAIL welcomes MMDR Amendment Act, 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Steel Authority of India Limited (SAIL) welcomes the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, notified by the Central Government on August 17, as a significant reform towards establishing a predictable fiscal regime and long-term policy certainty in the mineral sector.

The Amendment provides greater clarity and uniformity in mineral taxation and levies. It also addresses pending retrospective levies, thereby providing greater certainty and confidence to the mining industry.

For SAIL, with its substantial captive iron ore and coal mining operations, the reform is expected to improve the viability of mining operations, facilitate investment and mine devel-



opment, and strengthen long-term raw-material security. Greater predictability in the fiscal regime will support efficient utilisation and development of SAIL's mineral resources and will boost iron ore mining.

Importantly, the reform will also facilitate increased availability of iron ore in the domestic market. With improved viability and development of its captive mines, SAIL will be able to make additional iron ore available for sale in the market, in accordance with the applicable regulatory framework.

Q. Can the DPI be useful to stakeholders outside Government?

A. Yes. Subject to appropriate safeguards, standardised datasets and digital services can support Government institutions, research organisations, startups, technology partners and the wider WASH ecosystem. This can encourage digital solutions for pump repair, plumbing, tank cleaning, household-level water testing, leakage management and other O&M services, while also supporting innovation by laboratories, manufacturers and technology enterprises.

Q. What is the long-term outcome expected from Sujalam Bharat?

A. The objective is to create a trusted digital foundation for rural water utilities where States retain their governance role, citizens have greater visibility and accountability, and structured and authentic information can support better O&M, planning, source sustainability, innovation and responsible use of emerging technologies.

Ultimately, Sujalam Bharat is about converting the information generated across the rural water sector into better, more sustainable and accountable drinking-water services for citizens. (PNS)

MC²+ launches ignite programme to back deep-tech startups in India's energy sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

MC²+, a brand of MC² Foundation, has launched MC²+ Ignite, a sector-specific accelerator programme designed to support deep-tech startups building technologies for India's energy sector. With the vision and drive of the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (MoPNG), MC² Foundation has come up strongly in a very short period of time with the launch of MC²+ Ignite. The coming together of all the CMDs itself shows how deeply MoPNG is invested in this initiative.

On August 19, Neeraj Mittal, Secretary, MoPNG, along with the CMDs of all Oil & Gas companies and the Chairman, bp India, launched MC²+ Ignite at IIT Madras.

Addressing the gathering, Neeraj Mittal, Secretary, MoPNG, and Chairman, MC² Foundation, said that MC²



Foundation was set up to pool the technology problem statements of India's oil and gas energy majors onto a single platform, connect them directly to academic research and start-ups, and back the resulting ventures to global scale.

Explaining the need, Mittal pointed to the fragmentation the Foundation was created to end — "Several of our companies can be working on the very same catalyst at the same time. That is duplication of work, of investment and of bureaucra-

present, he committed MC² to the full journey — "We will be with you through the entire cycle — mentorship that is both technical and managerial, help with funds, and the visibility that a PSU will procure your product when it is ready. You should not have to worry about whether a market exists."

The launch witnessed the participation of senior leadership from across the energy sector including Arun Kumar Singh, Chairman & CEO, ONGC; Ranjit Rath, CMD, Oil India Limited; AS Sahney, Chairman, IOCL; Sanjay Khanna, CMD, BPCL and Director, MC² Foundation; Vikas Kaushal, CMD, HPCL and Director, MC² Foundation; Atul Gupta, CMD, Engineers India Limited; Madhukar Garg, Former President, R&D - Refining and Petrochemicals, Reliance Industries Limited; Kartikeya Dube, Chairman, bp India; and Sandeep Maheshwari, CEO, MC² Foundation.

Yes Bank's ₹600-crore loan assignment under ED scanner

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

A fresh complaint before the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and Economic Offences Wing (EOW) has raised questions over the assignment of a ₹600-crore loan given by Yes Bank to Privilege Power and Infrastructure Pvt Ltd (PPIPL) and later transferred to Suraksha Asset Reconstruction Private Limited (Suraksha ARC).

The complaint, filed by suspended PPIPL director Rakesh Kumar Wadhawan, seeks an FIR and investigation into the loan's classification, valua-



tion, assignment process and funding structure.

At the centre of the complaint is the allegation that the PPIPL account had not been classified as a Non-Performing Asset (NPA) when it was assigned to Suraksha ARC. Wadhawan has also questioned why a loan secured by assets and development rights

valued by the complaint at more than ₹2,000 crore was assigned when the reported outstanding dues stood at about ₹213.6 crore.

According to the complaint, the assignment consideration was approximately ₹155.3 crore. Of this, around ₹23.3 crore was reportedly paid in cash, while about ₹131.98 crore was discharged through Security Receipts (SRs) said to have been held by Yes Bank.

The complaint cites a Yes Bank internal or forensic review that allegedly raised concerns about the movement of funds involving

several entities. It also points to an alleged ₹100-crore increase in Fortune Integrated Assets Service's cash-credit limit before the assignment.

Wadhawan has asked the ED and EOW to examine whether the transaction involved circular movement of funds and whether the assignment followed an independent valuation and transparent bidding process.

The EOW investigation, if undertaken, will determine whether the alleged transactions occurred as claimed and whether any legal or regulatory violations took place.

DAILY SUDOKU

2		5	6					3
				5		2		
			1		7			
	6				1		8	4
	1		5		9		2	
3	5		4					1
			7		6			
	7			1				
	2				4	1		5

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (20.8.26)

9	7	2	6	1	3	4	5	8
4	6	5	9	7	8	1	2	3
1	3	8	4	5	2	7	9	6
3	9	1	8	2	5	6	4	7
2	8	4	7	6	1	9	3	5
6	5	7	3	9	4	8	1	2
7	1	3	2	4	6	5	8	9
5	2	6	1	8	9	3	7	4
8	4	9	5	3	7	2	6	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

FRIDAY | AUGUST 21, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9				10			11
12			13		14		
15		16				17	
18	19		20			21	22
23		24	25	26			
27							
28		29		30		31	
32			33				34
35							
36				37			
38					39		
40							
41							

ACROSS

9 Like the tired old cassette? (6,3)
10 Hint that makes clear one should follow
12 Much the same as "Care to"? (4)
13 It's a bad start getting one caught in the drawer (6)
14 Having a smell that, from the door, wafts round to us (7)
15 So one is bent, then, on entering, to win
17 Stick around, mind in a whirl, for the game (9)
18 With a claret concoction, adding the final note: it's sweet (7)
20 Then embraced the half-back: a Greek
21 Undecided, to begin with (4)
24 Dig in the cold, having on an Aran woolly (8)

DOWN

1 To put it plainly, is a while unconscious
2 Does it cost a fortune to post? (6)
3 In the game of ours, is beaten by me (8)
4 Do nothing to give you the impression
5 The brat broke, with a stick, the outside light (8)
6 Another member of the crew - old (6-4)
7 Took my place so I don't get into trouble
8 Open with a blunt corkscrew, to find, nothing inside (6)
11 Is a wrong number, silly! (7)
16 The coin possibly does contain copper
19 Delete the time - a third of a second (5)
20 Make up the number (3)

SOLUTION (20.8.26)

4	Til-ing	21	Common	15	Tim
7	Leon-ardo	23	La-M-b	16	Den
8	Ninety	24	Noes	18	Ambed
10	Glove	26	Web	20	Paste
11	Bank	27	Leer	21	C-a-B
13	Bank	29	Thin	22	No-r
14	Hare	32	Lely	23	Le-Glon
15	Talc	33	Pease	25	His
16	Don	34	Tira-de	28	Ele-Ct
17	Nail	35	Corporal	30	Harry
19	O-pen	36	Insect	31	Nelly
				32	Late
				33	Pips

BRIEFLY

Asian junior chess: Win for Chakraborty, Vignesh loses



Top seed Mayank Chakraborty began his campaign with an impressive win while two leading contenders – Vignesh Advait Vemula and Akhilbay Imangali – were held to a draw by lower-rated opponents in the Asian Junior Classical Championship here on Thursday. Vignesh was forced to share the point with Neemay Bhanushali, while Imangali of Kazakhstan was held by Rishaan Jain. The opening round in the girls section, however, produced a couple of notable upsets. Swara Lakshmi S Nair was held to a draw by Vakcheri Mohitha despite enjoying a significant rating advantage, while Aadya Gowda scored an impressive victory over the higher-rated WFM Mittika Mallick.

Another surprise result saw Liliya Belaya of Uzbekistan defeat the higher-rated Archita Agrawal of India. The Open Championship has attracted a strong field of 85 players representing nine federations. The tournament features six International Masters and eleven FIDE Masters, making it one of the strongest junior events in Asia. Leading the field is top seed International Master Mayank Chakraborty of India, rated 2500. The girls championship has attracted players from seven federations. The top three seeds, WFM Pratitee Bordoloi of India, WFM Mariya Kholyavko of Kazakhstan and WFM Shohradova Lala of Turkmenistan, opened their campaigns with convincing victories to move into the lead group after the first round. The championship was inaugurated by Grandmaster Vidit Gujrathi, who has been named a recipient of the prestigious Arjuna Award.

(PTI)

PSG moves its opening French league game at Parc des Princes



Paris Saint-Germain's opening game of its title defense in the French league against Rennes has been relocated at short notice because of damage to the champion's pitch following a heatwave this summer. Sunday's match will now take place in Rennes, French soccer's competitions committee announced late Wednesday. PSG said its pitch at Parc des Princes had deteriorated so much "that the current conditions did not allow the match to be held under satisfactory circumstances, particularly with regard to the safety and physical well-being of the players." The change of venue has been decided "in agreement" with Rennes, PSG said, and thanked its opponent for "making the match possible." "Paris Saint-Germain fully understands the inconvenience caused by this change for its supporters and all those who had planned to attend this match at the Parc des Princes," PSG added, saying "the club regrets this exceptional situation." PSG said it had "identified a solution for replacing the pitch at the Parc des Princes for the upcoming matches," starting with its next home game in Ligue 1 against Monaco on Sept. 4.

(AP)

Soccer fans launch global petition urging Infantino to resign over WC betrayal

GRAHAM DUNBAR ■ Geneva

A collection of soccer fan groups from around the world launched a petition Thursday calling for Gianni Infantino to resign as FIFA president after he tried to sell future World Cup profits to private investors.

The petition with the hashtag InfantinOut also



calls for "FIFA to be rebuilt so that the current debacle can

never happen again." "The shameful attempt by one individual – the FIFA President himself – to sell off the World Cup to private investors exposed a betrayal football will never forget," the petition said about Infantino's plan for a commercial spinoff, which he dropped amid a furious backlash.

DWYER TIPS INDIA, SAYS CONSISTENCY CAN MAKE THEM HARD TO BEAT

MONA PARTHSARATHI ■ Amstelveen

Former Australia legend Jamie Dwyer does not doubt that the Indian team has the talent, skills and infrastructure to become a dominant force in world hockey but says the side needs consistency to realise its true potential. Dwyer, one of the greatest forwards of his generation, played 365 internationals for Australia and scored 244 goals, including the momentous extra-time winner in the 2004 Athens Olympic final against the Netherlands in 2004. He was also part of Australia's World Cup-winning teams in 2010 and 2014.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lausanne

The budding rivalry between rising Sri Lankan star Rumesh Pathirage and Indian ace Neeraj Chopra will once again be an intriguing battle when the two square off in the Lausanne Diamond League meet here on Friday with a spot in the DL grand finale in Brussels at stake. The duo will be up against each other three weeks after Pathirage clinched the gold and Chopra finished with a silver in the Glasgow Commonwealth Games. The 23-year-old Pathirage has been in the form of his life this season, having also won the Doha and Rome Diamond

League meetings, besides clinching gold in Glasgow with a throw of 89.75m. He also breached the coveted 90m mark with a season-leading throw of 92.62m in Rome in June. In fact, the Sri Lankan has won eight of the nine competitions he has participated so far in the season. Chopra, on the other hand, is on a comeback trail after recovering from a lower back injury that has troubled him since September last year. The injury delayed his return until the Diamond League in Doha. He was not 100 per cent fit in Glasgow but was able to win a silver with a season's best throw of 85.83m. "I can't say my fitness



is there like before. But I'm getting there slowly," the 28-year-old Chopra had said at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games. After the Commonwealth Games,

Marwah. He would be hoping to make further improvement in the three weeks after Glasgow CWG. One of the most consistent javelin throwers ever, two-time Olympic medallist Chopra has finished outside the top-two in just two competitions in the last five years. Athletics Federation of India selection committee chairman Adille Sumariwalla has warned against writing off Chopra, saying the superstar Indian should not be scrutinised too harshly for winning a silver at times. The Lausanne Diamond League was to see the most high-profile competition in recent memory but it has lost some sheen with the pulling

out of the reigning world champion Arshad Nadeem and a newly-crowned European champion Julian Weber of Germany. Nadeem has been struggling since winning gold in the 2024 Olympics with a record throw of 92.97m. Since then, his best has been 86.40m while winning gold in the Asian Championships last year. This season, his best has been 78.63m, and he finished ninth in the Glasgow Commonwealth Games with 77.41m. Weber is the only second javelin thrower after Pathirage to have breached the 90m mark with his gold-winning 90.40m effort in the European Championships in Birmingham.

German Cup faces disruption with fans planning protests

CIARAN FAHEY ■ Berlin

The first round of the German Cup faces disruption this weekend with several supporter groups planning major protests against the use of video technology during games.

The new German soccer season begins Friday with Bundesliga teams Eintracht Frankfurt and Stuttgart facing lower-league opposition among other games, with the first round continuing through the weekend and Monday. There will be no video assistance for referees in the first round for technical and financial reasons with 64 teams involved, but VAR will be introduced from the



second round for the first time this season. News agency DPA on Thursday published a statement it said was circulating among the fanbases of teams involved, declaring their intent to protest. "We see football as it should be in the first round of the cup getting under-

rhythm, the flow of the game suffers significantly from protracted interruptions. We are also painfully aware that it has destroyed the game's most emotional moments," it continued. "Even fans who were initially open to and positive about the innovation now acknowledge, after nine years, that VAR has fundamentally altered the character of the game." Fans have interrupted games before in Germany using tennis balls or pyrotechnics. Last season's German Cup final was played under a cloud of smoke from fans' fireworks. This season in Germany, the referee's video assistant's powers are to be expanded. (AP)

Golf: Theegala needs top finish for Tour Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ St Louis (US)

Sahith Theegala needs a finish pretty close to the top to make it to the Tour Championship as he tees up for the 2026 BMW Championship which is a high-stakes week on the PGA Tour. The event cuts down the field to the top 50 players. The 2026 BMW Championship runs from August 20-23 at East Lake.

Hosted at the historic Bellverie Country Club in St. Louis, Missouri, this Par 70, 7,448-yard track features over 70 penal sand traps, demanding elite ball-striking and precision long-iron play. With a massive \$20 million purse on the line, there is no 36-hole cut, guaranteeing four full days of intense drama as



the field claws for the ultimate prize. The field of 50 will be trimmed to 30 after this week's BMW Championship and it carries another set of rewards. For starters, those 30

will play at the TOUR Championship for the chance to be crowned the FedExCup champion. The other carrot is exemptions into next year's majors. One of the historic storylines of the 2026 FedEx Cup Playoffs is the unprecedented representation of Indian-origin golfers. A record-breaking group of four players advanced through to the Playoffs and three have secured their places in this week's elite 50-man field.

The Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited
GSTIN : 29AAACT6167C123
Branch : Chawni Bazar 3462, Gali Bajrangbali Chawni Bazar, Delhi-110006, India | T : +91 (0)11 23260795 | F : +91 (0)11 23260795
E : chawni@jkmail.com | W : www.jkbank.net

POSSESSION NOTICE
Notice under Section 13 (4) of the SARFAESI ACT, 2002 read with Rule 8 (1) of the Security (Enforcement) Interest Rules, 2002
Whereas Mr. Reyaz Ahmad Mir, as the Authorized Officer of the Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers under section 13 (12) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notice dated 15-10-2025 thereby calling upon the Borrowers namely: 1. Mrs. Harshita Grover W/O Mr. Aman Grover (Borrower/Mortgagor) & 2. Mr. Aman Grover S/o Mr. Jasvinder Singh (Borrower) Both Residents of A-201 2nd Floor, Vikas Puri Tikla Nagar New Delhi-110018 to repay an amount of Rs.51,41,534.36 (Fifty-One Lac Forty-One thousand five hundred and thirty-four Rupees and thirty six Paise only) being the balance outstanding as on 29-09-2025 in the accounts of the Borrower, within 60 days from the date of the said notice together with the future interest and other charges thereon. The said borrower having failed to repay the said amount, notice is hereby given to the said borrower in particular and the public in general that the undersigned being authorized officer of the J & K Bank Ltd. has taken possession of the mortgage property described herein below, in exercise of the powers conferred on me under section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules, on this the **19th day of August, 2026**. The said borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned against dealing with the said property in any manner whatsoever and any dealings with the said property will be subject to the charge of the J&K Bank Limited for the amount in aggregating to Rs. 55,21,151.36 (Rupees Fifty-Five Lac Twenty-one thousand one hundred fifty one and thirty six paise) as on 31-07-2026 together with future interest thereon from 01-08-2026 and other charges incurred or to be incurred. The borrower's attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.
Description of the Immoveable Property
Residential Flat in First Floor, Front side without Roof/Terrace rights out of Built-up property on plot No. 72 & 73, land measuring 90 sq. yds (out of total area 200sq yds) out of Kharsa No 457, situated in the revenue estate of village Nawada, Mazra Hastal Colony, Delhi, colony known as Mohan Garden Extn, in block west east area, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059 with proportionate and free-hold rights of the land under the said property with one small car parking right in the still standing in the name of Mrs Harshita Grover.
Dated : 19/08/2026
Place : New Delhi
Authorized Officer
Jammu and Kashmir Bank Ltd

STATE BANK OF INDIA

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59 Community Centre, Naraina Industrial Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 25.09.2026 FOR MOVABLE ASSETS
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 25.09.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under :-
Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property /ies is/ are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Name of the Authorised (Signatory)
1.	MR. RAJEEV KUMAR Auto Loan A/c.: 43247696358	Rs.8,07,235/- as on 15.11.2025 plus Interest and other incidental Charges etc. thereafter	Make & Model: MARUTI BREZZA LXI CNG Regn. No.: DL9CBF7285 Engine No.: K15C9N569447 Chassis No.: MA3RYHK15RG456856 Date of Regn.: 21.08.2024 Odometer: 46488 Kms Fuel: Petrol/ CNG (Pearl Arctic White)	₹ 6,25,000.00 ₹ 62,500.00 ₹ 1,000.00 *GST as applicable	Mr. Anil Kumar Chaudhary (Chief Manager) HLC, Naraina, New Delhi Mr. Amit Kumar Mob: 9205101634

Last Date and Time within which EMD to be remitted : 24.09.2026 before 23:59 Hrs. Bank account in which EMD to be remitted: 4897932507926. Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his /her/their bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPDESHK: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:
(1) E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line" on 25.09.2026 from 10:00 AM to 16:00 Hrs. at <https://baanknet.com>. The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
(2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
(3) The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 24.09.2026 From 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM., Contact Person - Mr. Amit Kumar, Mobile No.: 9205101634 (Resolution Agent).
(4) *Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount, viz sale value.
(5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/ligths/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.
The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/ dues.
(6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be related towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property / amount.
(7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>
Date: 20.08.2026 Place: New Delhi Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina, New Delhi

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA			TENDER NOTICE			
SR. No.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	FOREST BHIWANI	BHIWANI 1ST BLOCK NEW PLANTATION & MAINTENANCE AND 12 OTHER WORKS	18.08.2026 25.08.2026	4,87,08,911/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9813207322 dfo.bhiwani@yahoo.com
2	FOREST BHIWANI	BAWANI KHERA BLOCK MAINTENANCE OF PLANTS CAMPA SCHEME & 14 OTHER WORKS	19.08.2026 27.08.2026	6,78,22,682/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9813207322 dfo.bhiwani@yahoo.com
3	HEALTH DEPARTMENT/ OFFICE OF CIVIL SURGEON FATEHABAD	PUBLIC HEALTH ACTION FOR TB PATIENTS IN PRIVATE SECTOR	20.08.2026 02.09.2026	EMD 60,000/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9813185327 dhs.csfb@hry.nic.in
4	PWD B&R BRANCH, SIRSA	CONSTRUCTION OF NEW PWD REST HOUSE AT DABWALI IN SIRSA DISTRICT + 2 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 01.09.2026	6,84,16,094/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01666220530 pwd-eeep1-sirsa@hry.nic.in
5	IRRIGATION & W.R. DEPARTMENT, PANIPAT HARYANA	RECONSTRUCTION OF BRIDGE AT RD 4206,13000, 16040 AND 17918 ON SAMALKHA DISTY + 2 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 07.09.2026	1,05,44,125/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466159501 xenpusdiv@yahoo.in
6	PANCHAYATI RAJ SONIPAT	CONSTRUCTION OF SAINTI CHAUPAL AT VILLAGE BAROTA BLOCK GOHANA DISTRICT SONIPAT	CLOSING DATE 26.08.2026	23,75,751/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416391006 prexeeng.snp@gmail.com
7	PANCHAYATI RAJ SONIPAT	RATE CONTRACT OF PURCHASE OF STATIONERY IN DITS SONIPAT	CLOSING DATE 25.08.2026	-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416391006 prexeeng.snp@gmail.com
8	PANCHAYATI RAJ , AMBALA	DPLAN CONST.OF BRICK PAVED RASTA FROM YARA POWER H/O TO SHUKBIR SINGH FILED AT VILL. KASERLA KALAN BLOCK BARARA + 15 WORKS	19.08.2026 25.08.2026	2,47,71,245/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0171-2551368 prexeeng.amb@hry.nic.in
9	KALPANA CHAWLA GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE KARNAL	E-TENDER FOR SUPPLY MEDICINE AND CONSUMABLE (INJECTION SURFACTANT SML) AT KCGMC, KARNAL	25.08.2026 02.09.2026	EMD 10,000/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896154463 director.kcghc-hry@gov.in
10	AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE DEPARTMENT BHIWANI	PERCOLATION OF POND AT PANCHAYAT LAND NEAR MOTIPURA MINOR WITH RAMP AND UNDERGROUND PIPE LINE FROM MOTIPURA MINOR TO POND, VILLAGE- LILAS, BLOCK- SIWANI, DISTT- BHIWANI + 8 WORKS	19.08.2026 26.08.2026	1,02,11,418/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9215910040 ascobhiwani@gmail.com
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in						RO 48452-I-27-7

Kuldeep at cross roads: India look at Saransh for 2nd Test

G UNNIKRIISHNAN
■ Colombo

The fifth day pitch at the Galle stadium was abrasive enough for Kuldeep Yadav to weave his magic. But the left-arm wrist spinner managed a forgettable figure of 11-0-38-0.

It was clear that India skipper Shubman Gill viewed Kuldeep as the third spin option behind Ravindra Jadeja and Manav Suthar, who jointly bowled 46.4 overs, and the duo plucked 14 wickets between them.

So, the easy way for Kuldeep's downswing is to blame the skipper or management for not showing enough trust in Kuldeep. But

the fact remains that in his 11 overs, the 31-year-old too did not provide enough samples for the leadership group to give him more overs. Even in the first innings, Kuldeep should thank the athleticism of Gill for the wicket of Kamindu Mendis, his lone wicket in the first Test.

Of course, he tried to get out of the rut, going around the wicket to purchase more zip and bounce off the pitch. The line of attack took the LBW out of the equation, and the withered Kookaburra ball too did not help his cause.

Now, it is certain that the think tank will mull replacing Kuldeep with off-spinner Saransh Jain for the second Test at the Sinhalese Sports

Club, starting from Sunday. It makes a legit case too as Sri Lankans have several left-handers in their top-order and off-spinner is a natural weapon against them.

Former India leg-spinner L Sivaramakrishnan offered a piece of tip for struggling Kuldeep. "See first thing, white ball he will get wickets because batsmen are looking to score off him and will play shots. So, he will get wickets. Here (in Tests), he needs to forget that. But you need a different approach when bowling with three fielders around the bat, and only one fielder probably saving the boundary. The consistency of line and length needs to be top class to make an effect,"



Sivaramakrishnan said. One line of thought is that Kuldeep should bowl faster through the air to get more purchase from the track. He generally operates in the 82-85 kmph territory and a few experts think that the Uttar

Pradesh bowler should move up the speedometer by a few clicks into the 90s. However, Sivaramakrishnan strongly refuted that thinking. "See what happens now that if the pace bowlers get hit, they instantly take the

pace off the deliveries. Similarly, if the spinners go for runs, they are now looking to increase the pace. Hence, what I am saying is that this advice to bowl fast is the worst piece of advice Kuldeep is getting now," he said. Instead, the former India spinner asked Kuldeep to focus on his alignment and natural speeds.

"See if you are bowling faster then the ball spends less time in the air, and there will be less revs on the ball. But if you bowl slower, it allows the ball to spend a lot more time in the air, and take a lot more spin. Make no mistake, spin happens in the air, and turn happens off the pitch. They are two different

things." "So, when people ask Kuldeep to bowl quicker through the air, what happens is that the ball skids off the pitch, and without that grip on the pitch there is not much chance of turning either." "Skidding off the surface just makes the ball go in a straight line. Kuldeep has to think on this, and not only him but several spinners are suffering from this and that's why the number of leg-spinners playing Test cricket is getting decreased," he detailed.

Kuldeep's last impact outing was last year against the West Indies at New Delhi when he took eight wickets in the match to lead India's victory march.

Perhaps, lack of preparation too hindered Kuldeep's outing in Galle.

While Suthar extensively prepared with Kookaburra balls after his debut match against Afghanistan, Kuldeep had just one side game against SLC XI ahead of the first Test. In that match also he operated in only one innings - 18-0-76-2 - without making a real effect. The senior spinner also appeared in five List A matches for Yorkshire in this period, but bowling with Dukes ball in them. Now will he get another chance at SSC to showcase his incredible skills? The answer will have a prominent link to his immediate Test career. (PTI)

Tough to replace Murali and Herath, need to trust new spinners: Wijetunge

G UNNIKRIISHNAN
■ Colombo

For Sri Lanka, the sight of Indian left-arm spinner Manav Suthar walking away with a 10-wicket Test-haul was not just a reminder of fortress Galle being no longer impenetrable.

It also triggered questions on where exactly are the spin reserves of a team which once had Muttiah Muralitharan and Rangana Herath rattling opponents at the same venue. Galle was a bankable venue for Sri Lanka where they have a fairly good record of 27 wins in 50 Test. The 165-run loss to India, which came a year after being whitewashed by Australia at the same venue, has highlighted the fact that the team needs to regain a lot of lost ground at this venue. The heady days of their own spinners dominating proceedings have long faded. But

Piyal Wijetunge, the renowned coach who is now heading the spin wing at the Sri Lanka Cricket's National High Performance Centre here, believes that the island nation has enough talent to regain the glory days.

"See, it's tough to replace Murali and Rangana. They were unique and their experience and skills cannot be easily replaced. They are once in a life-time bowlers," Wijetunge said.

"But we need to trust our new spinners, who I believe have enough talent to serve the team for a long time. They will be better with time and more matches," he added. Sri Lanka handed a debut to off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha in the Test against India, and the 25-year-old off-spinner was impressive while taking four wickets in the match. Wijetunge thought Nuwantha showed enough promise to warrant a long



run. "He is a special talent. He needs some patient and careful handling. He did well in the practice match (SLC XI vs India) ahead of the Test match, and was drafted into the national team." So what makes him a player to watch out for?

"He is a tall person and can bowl that off-spin and top-spin with ease without giving away too much indication. "But these are early days in his career and he needs to improve his tactical awareness -- what should be done

at what stage of the match, how to operate against left-arm and right-arm batsmen," he elaborated.

"But that will come to him as he plays a lot more matches, you know, the competitive match exposure. I am sure the management will do the needful," he added. In the not so distant past, Sri Lanka had a new crop of promising spinners in the likes of Lasith Embuldeniya and Praveen Jayawickrama. Jayawickrama, who is now 27, played five Tests between 2021 and

2022 for 25 wickets, while Embuldeniya, who is now 29, played 17 Tests between 2019 and 2022 for 71 wickets. They showed early promise but have been sidelined in the last four years for different reasons.

Wijetunge though has not lost hope. "The door is not closed on them, I think. If they do well in domestic matches they can always come in. If you see, Embuldeniya was part of the Sri Lankan squad that toured South Africa in 2024 October-November. "Jayawickrama, as you know, has some personal problems (one-year ban by ICC in 2024 for breaching anti-corruption code during the Lanka Premier League), but he is on track for a comeback. "...they need to take wickets everywhere, like Embuldeniya had a good tour to SA in 2019. They did well in our conditions but that is not enough. So, they need to build on it for

consistent team selection," he said. Sri Lanka has a unique process to identify young talent, a multi-tier system involving colleges, districts, provinces and four super provinces. While Wijetunge is not directly involved with that four-tier pathway, the coach is delighted to see the talent flow from that pool to the High Performance Centre.

"We have different coaches at that level. But I can say that we have strong grassroots cricket from which a lot of talented players emerge as we do selection twice a year from it for the academy. "I can tell you some names like Traveen, Vishva Lahiru, Wanuja, Akash Vigneshwaran etc are coming up. As I said, it's all about giving the right coaching and preparing them technically and mentally for a higher grade of cricket. We have hopes for them," he signed off. (PTI)

IPL generation playing good Test cricket a mystery, says Manjrekar



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former India batter Sanjay Manjrekar has termed it a "mystery" how the IPL generation has been able to seamlessly adapt to the demands of Test cricket, comparing the modern players' transition from T20s to the longest format to pop singers attempting classical ragas. Manjrekar marvelled at the ability of the current generation, which has grown up playing T20 cricket, to make the significant technical adjustment required for red-ball cricket.

"Modern pop singers, if they are asked to do classical singing, ragas, then it will be very difficult. But these people are doing that. It is a mystery to me that the generation of IPL, the generation of T20, how do they play such good Test cricket? In both game of ball and game

of gain," Manjrekar said on The Great Indian Cricket Show on Doordarshan.

He was particularly impressed by the adaptability of modern batters, given the vastly different demands of T20 and Test cricket.

"More in case of batting, because there is a lot of difference between T20 batting and Test batting," he added.

With India's young squad featuring several IPL and T20 stars currently engaged in a two-Test series against Sri Lanka, Manjrekar's observations underline the changing nature of the modern cricketer, who is increasingly expected to switch between vastly different formats with ease. The ability to shift from the aggressive tempo of T20 cricket to having patience, technique and concentration demanded in Tests has become a defining feature of the current generation of Indian players. (PTI)

Sinquefield Cup: Praggnanandhaa loses to Wesley So in Armageddon

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ St Louis (USA)

Indian Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa lost the finals in the Armageddon game against eventual champion American Wesley So to finish second in the Sinquefield Cup here.

After drawing with Anish Giri of the Netherlands in the final Classical game, Praggnanandhaa forced a tiebreaker against Wesley So who was leading the tournament for most of the rounds. Wesley So was able to play out a draw with black pieces to win the tournament,



which is a part of the Grand Chess Tour.

The rules clearly stipulated that the tied players would play two rapid games. If the tie is still unresolved, one final

Armageddon with five minutes for white and four for black will be played, wherein black wins the match if he draws.

As it happened both the

rapid games ended in draws, leaving the score tied at 1-1. In the final Armageddon, Praggnanandhaa had the more difficult chance of winning with white which the Indian could not do and the game ended in a draw.

However, the silver lining for Praggnanandhaa was that he stood first at the end of the last event and has now qualified for the grand finale later this year. For the records, Praggnanandhaa scored 35.5 in the total tour which was a full point clear of Wesley So. Finishing third was Fabiano Caruana of United States while Vincent Keymer ended

fourth. In the Grand finale, the top four finishers in the tour will participate.

Praggnanandhaa tried to get past Wesley So in the Classical game but Anish Giri was quite resourceful in finding some very resourceful moves when it mattered the most. As it happened in the game after the trade off of a couple of minor pieces, the opinion of the pundits was undivided about the result of the game and it was drawn as predicted.

Wesley So is a tough customer and a very solid player. Sindarov had to win with black but that is probably one

of the hardest tasks against the American as he simply played solidly, exchanged pieces at will and reached a Bishop and pawns endgame where the draw was a just result. Results Final Round 9: Wesley So (Usa, 5.5) drew with Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb, 5); Jordan Van Foreest (Ned, 2) drew with Vincent Keymer (Ger, 5); Levon Aronian (Usa, 4) drew with Sevan Samuels (Usa, 4.5) Fabiano Caruana (Usa, 4.5) drew with Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (Fra, 4.5); R Praggnanandhaa (Ind, 5.5) drew with Anish Giri (Ned, 4).

Tiebreak: Wesley So beat Praggnanandhaa 1-1, 1-0.

Sindhu bow out; Treasa-Gayatri enter World Championships quarters

AMIT KUMAR DAS ■ New Delhi

India suffered a big blow at the World Championships as PV Sindhu and Ayush Shetty faced contrasting defeats in the pre-quarterfinals, bringing the country's singles campaign to an end here on Thursday.

Two-time Olympic medalist Sindhu's hopes of winning an unprecedented sixth World Championships medal ended with a gruelling 11-21 21-15 17-21 loss to China's world No. 3 Wang Zhi Yi, who battled severe cramps in both legs to advance to the quarterfinals.

Earlier, Shetty suffered a tame 19-21 11-21 defeat against Indonesian nemesis Alwi Farhan in the men's singles pre-quarterfinals.

The 21-year-old Shetty, who

had created a flutter by stunning defending champion and world No. 1 Shi Yu Qi in the opening round, went down 19-21 11-21 to world No. 12 Farhan.

It was his fifth defeat in eight meetings against the 11th-seeded Indonesian, bringing the curtains down on India's men's singles campaign. Lakshya Sen had bowed out of the premier tournament on Wednesday.

Earlier in the day, India's women's doubles pair of Treasa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand moved a step closer to a medal by reaching the quarterfinals with a straight-game win over Japanese seventh seeds Rin Iwanaga and Kie Nakanishi.

The unseeded Indian pair, on a comeback trail after



Treasa recovered from an injury, produced a dominant performance to outwit the world No. 7 Japanese pair 21-16 21-12 in a one-sided contest. It was the first quarterfinal appearance by an Indian women's doubles pair at the World Championships since

Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponnappa achieved the feat in 2015. Playing at her 11th World Championships, Sindhu entered the match with a 3-5 head-to-head record against Wang.

The two traded some good rallies early on, splitting the

first 14 points. At 8-7, a gruelling 41-shot rally ended with Wang finding a precise drop at the forecourt. Sindhu responded with a superb slow drop from the back line.

A lovely return of serve gave Sindhu a two-point advantage at the mid-game interval.

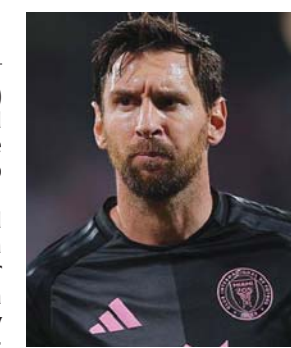
The Chinese player then surged ahead 14-9 before spraying one into the net. Unforced errors began to haunt Sindhu as she slipped 10-18 behind. She responded with two sharp cross-court smashes to stay afloat, but another attempt floated long to make it 19-11 in Wang's favour. Wang earned nine game points when Sindhu found net again. The Indian then faltered in a net duel, allowing opening game to slip away. (PTI)

Messi has a goal and assist as Inter Miami plays the Union to 2-2 draw

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Asan (Korea)

Chester (USA), Aug 20 (AP) Lionel Messi had a goal and assist as Inter Miami and the Philadelphia Union played to a 2-2 draw.

Messi's cross was headed by Luis Suarez into the path of forward Daniel Pinter for the first Inter Miami goal in the 21st minute Wednesday night. Messi cut inside to his preferred left foot from 12 yards out in the 26th and curled a shot into the corner of the net for his first goal since returning to action following the death of his father. Messi has 13 goals and



nine assists in 17 MLS games this season. He has six goals and four assists in six matches in all competitions against the Union.

Indiana Vassilev scored on a volley in the first half to

give the Union the lead, then 18-year-old defender Neil Pierre headed home his third goal in five games this season in the 58th minute to tie the score. Cavan Sullivan, the Union's 16-year-old midfielder, was credited with his seventh assist of the season on Vassilev's goal.

Union forward Milan Iloski appeared to put the Union ahead in the 62nd minute, but the goal was reviewed and waved off with Pierre offside in the buildup. The game ended with a pair of red cards in stoppage time to Yannick Bright and Sullivan for a scuffle off the ball.

Gukesh's World Championship battle will be a test of mind, not chess: Vidit

HIMANK NEGI ■ New Delhi

Grandmaster Vidit Gujrathi believes reigning world champion D Gukesh's title defence against Uzbek challenger Javokhir Sindarov will be a test of mental strength more than chess ability, with the Indian needing to put behind him a difficult run and rediscover the form that made 2024 an exceptional year.

Gukesh has endured an inconsistent phase since his World Championship

triumph, while Sindarov heads into the marquee clash in excellent form. Vidit, however, said a dip in results does not necessarily indicate a decline in a player's ability. "In chess, performances, if you are not Magnus Carlsen, come in stages. For example, 2024 was an exceptional year for Gukesh. Every tournament, he had the Midas touch. Whatever he played, he was winning," Vidit told PTI.

He said form among elite players is influenced by

several factors beyond their chess strength. "Their strength is very high. A lot of things affect form -- mindset, physical condition and pressure. Sport is about whether you can bring your best on that day." According to Vidit, Gukesh continues to work hard and has brought fresh ideas to his games but has struggled to produce the efficiency that characterised his rise to the world title.

"Usually he would convert very well, but now he is missing those wins. He is



coming under time pressure a lot. He is working very hard. That's very clear from the games. But something is missing," Vidit, however, felt Gukesh could still return to his best, provided he can overcome the mental baggage of his recent results.

"That doesn't mean that in the World Championship, he cannot go back to his 2024 version. It will require a lot of inner strength because when you don't do well, you struggle mentally."

"So, it's a test of his mental

strength rather than a test of his chess. Can he forget everything that has happened this year and go as a challenger, not as someone defending the World Championship?"

Vidit expects a closely-contested match if Gukesh can achieve that mental reset, though he acknowledged Sindarov currently has the momentum.

"Both of them are very strong players. Of course, right now, Sindarov is in better shape. There is no

doubt in that."

India will face another major challenge at the upcoming Chess Olympiad, where the defending champions will rely on the depth of a team that includes several players currently enjoying good runs.

Vidit singled out R Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi and Nihal Sarin, saying their form augurs well for India, though he cautioned against considering the defending champions overwhelming favourites. (PTI)